Café de la Luna · Kids' Series

Seven Kings

All the Strings



Book IV · Volume II

Evgeniy Tyurkin, Luna, Muse

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An independent story lives in the margins.

1. Light Through the Stone

They let the pigeon in because it was disrupting the meeting.

It paced the outer windowsill, tapping the glass with its beak, always returning to the pane behind the gray-haired king. The secretary tried twice to drive it off with a rolled sheet of paper. The pigeon retreated two steps, waited out the dangerous movement, and began tapping again.

“Open it,” the king said.

A report lay before him. Yesterday’s villages were underlined once; those from the

night, twice. The secretary was reading only the names, without repeating after each one how many households they had managed to evacuate. This did not make the reading seem any shorter.

The pigeon flew across the table. One corner of the report lifted, and the king pinned it down with his palm. The bird settled on the back of an empty chair. A flat green case was fastened to its leg, so light it had first been mistaken for a leaf.

The case bore Tom Brown’s seal. Inside was a card made of transparent emerald.

The king picked it up carefully. Its cool edge rested in the crease of his finger. Through the stone he could see the table, the paper, his own hand—everything shifted a little, as though the objects had moved while he was looking elsewhere. The black lines of the report turned green. A double underline split into two uneven tracks.

The gold lettering did not move.

The face bore his name and a date. No place, no hour. He turned the card over. This side of the stone was perfectly smooth.

The gray-haired king raised the card closer to the window. The patch of sunlight on the table

stretched. Within the green light, the paper looked as though young leaves were casting their shade across it.

He had once seen Brown pour water without lifting a pitcher. An empty glass had suddenly become full—and the performer had immediately begun talking about something else, as though the genuinely interesting part had not even started.

The king lowered his hand.

The report was lying on the table again.

“What comes next?” he asked.

The secretary found the line where they had been interrupted.

“Fire has cut across the northern road. They propose taking the people out across the border. If the crossing by the mills is opened, they can get through before the wind changes.”

“Have they written there yet?”

“They’re asking your permission to make the request.”

The king looked at the pigeon. It had drawn its head into its shoulders and was preening its breast. It did not look like a messenger who could answer another question.

“Give it here,” the gray-haired king said.

In the margin he wrote: “Continue evacuation by available roads.” Then his hand paused. A request to his neighbor would need another sheet, a salutation, a signature. He would have to state the number of people he could no longer protect himself.

The card lay beside him. He moved it onto a clean patch of table so it would not get scratched.

The gray-haired king picked up the card again. It bore his name. Below it was a date, not many days away.

Nothing else.

He turned the stone over. From the back, his own name read in reverse.

“Where?” the king asked.

The secretary leaned toward the card, but the king did not hand it over.

“Where am I to go?”

The pigeon shifted its feet on the back of the chair. There was no use asking it.

By noon, the sages had been summoned to the palace.

The last time, they had promised the king clear weather for a walk with his daughter. Their explanation had been thorough: wind, clouds, observations from

preceding days. At first the sun really did shine. Half an hour later a squall blew in; servants stripped off their cloaks to shelter the king and the girl from the rain. Back at the palace, the gray-haired king heard an equally thorough explanation of why it had rained. Since then, a convincing argument had not been enough to reassure him.

They came with books, magnifying glasses, and a habit of never leaving a question unanswered for too long. One immediately asked whether the date should be interpreted according to the old calendar. Another objected that they must first establish which calendar the

first man meant. The young secretary mentioned a fisherman who had advised taking cloaks that morning, before the ill-fated walk.

“A fisherman,” one of the sages repeated. “And where did he study?”

The secretary fell silent. A university seal hung from the sage’s case.

Miren, the chief sage, was the last to enter. He was a hundred and forty years old. He moved his staff forward and kept his sleeve clear of the door latch: a gold path ran across the green silk, a path better known in this palace than many real ones.

When Miren had arrived here from the north, he had worn no such path. He had worn fur boots, an old fur coat, and a moth-eaten hat. He held the hat in both hands. The king saw him outside the audience chamber and ordered the vagrant removed.

The guards took him out. At the gates, one asked where he would go now.

“First I’ll sit down, if you don’t mind. Then we’ll see.”

They gave him water. He did not drink at once: he waited for his hands to stop shaking. The guard who had brought the cup complained that he had lost the key to the service gate that

morning and would now have to answer to his superior.

Miren asked when he had last opened the gate. Then what he had been carrying. A bucket, it turned out. Then whom he had handed it to. They went to the stable; the key lay on the edge of the water trough, where the guard had set it down to free his hand.

“But I already looked here.”

“I didn’t know where to look,” Miren replied. “I had to ask.”

They let him spend the night in the guardhouse. They did not tell the king about him.

“Three days,” the senior guard warned. “We can find food and water. But then you must go. If anyone finds out we disobeyed the order, we’ll be the ones answering for it.”

Miren promised.

On the second day, rain flooded the spot beneath the shelter where the old yard dog slept. They drove him into another corner, but he kept returning to his wet bedding. Miren looked up. Water was running off the edge of the roof straight onto a place that had once been dry. He asked for a piece of gutter; one guard brought it, another held the ladder. They diverted the water into a ditch. The dog settled onto

fresh, dry straw and sighed as though he had finally explained something simple to the humans.

On the third day, two children from the kitchens quarreled outside the guardhouse. The boy was pulling a pitcher toward himself; the girl would not let go. Miren did not try to decide who had taken it first. He asked each what they needed it for. One had been told to carry water; the other, to fetch an empty pitcher for milk. The girl went with the boy, waited while he poured out the water, and came back with the pitcher. They still argued over who would carry it along the way, but now they were going in the same direction.

The king heard about the key, then the dog, then the children. He ordered them to summon the man responsible for all this.

The guards exchanged glances.

“He’s the one you ordered us to remove, Your Majesty.”

The king did not answer at once.

“Did you remove him?”

“From outside the audience chamber. We gave him three days under a roof. He leaves today.”

The king dismissed them. Then he found some old clothes with no marks of the court and went to the guardhouse himself. Miren sat on a bench, mending his fur

coat. Beside him lay a bundle of bread for the road.

The king sat at the other end of the bench. He did not mention his title.

“My daughter has almost stopped talking to me,” he said at last. “What should I do?”

Miren laid his sewing in his lap.

“How long has this been going on?”

“Her mother died. I do my best to see that she wants for nothing. I don’t speak of her mother. Why cause her pain again?”

“Do you miss her?”

The king nodded.

“Tell your daughter that.”

“She already knows.”

“Perhaps. But has she heard it from you?”

The king looked at the mended sleeve. He had no answer.

The guard was changing at the gate. The king watched the man who now checked the key at his belt every time.

“And how can you tell whether someone means you well or is simply afraid?”

“Let them disagree with you.”

“Is that all?”

“And then don’t punish them. Once may not be enough: they still have to learn to believe you.”

The king looked at his hands for a long time.

“And if you’ve already made a mistake? In front of everyone. And everyone remembers.”

Miren showed him the crooked seam.

“I’m about to unpick this part. If I leave it so you won’t notice the mistake, the sleeve will come apart on the road.”

“People aren’t sleeves.”

“Which means you can ask them what needs mending. Sometimes they know better than we do.”

He pulled out the faulty stitch.

“A girl who tended cows once explained that to me. Not the sewing.”

Miren had been born into a family of sages. At three, he was taught to read and write; later, he was sent to an exclusive school. Boys and girls studied separately, and there were no peasant children there at all. He graduated from one university, then another. Logic, mathematics, physics, astronomy, geography all came easily to him. He grew used to reaching the answer before his teachers and decided that the same must be true of everyone else. He often answered before hearing the whole question.

When his long education was over and he grew bored, he went to tend cows.

Cows ate grass and gave milk. This interested him more than the motion of heavenly bodies. Once, he chewed some grass himself. No milk resulted. He offered bunches of it to other animals. The cat turned away; the dog gave him such a look that he had to end the experiment. He recorded his observations, argued with chemists and alchemists. They showed him white plant sap. He replied that being white did not make something milk.

One day, a calf squeezed up to its mother and began to suckle.

Miren put down his notebook. The girl who had tended this herd since childhood listened to his question.

“She eats and drinks, doesn’t she?” the girl said. “Her body takes what it needs from the food and uses it with water to make milk. Here, in her udder. Usually, the milk starts when a calf is born. It needs to eat.”

“And if it walks away?”

“The milk won’t disappear just because it’s walked away. Suckling or regular milking helps her body keep making milk.”

She would not even have been admitted to his school. Not because she could not have

learned her letters: she had simply been born into the wrong family. Yet Miren stood before her with all his university learning and had just received the answer he had spent so long looking for in the wrong places.

In his notebook, he crossed out two words: “for us.” Now he knew where milk came from, and he saw whom it was needed for first of all. The girl returned to the herd. He asked if he could go with her and ask a few more questions.

Later, he read again, compared what he found, returned to his notes. There were no fewer questions. Only now he could leave one until tomorrow, drink

some milk, and listen to someone who had never read a single one of his books.

“And did you listen to her right away?” asked the man on the bench.

“No. First I wanted to explain why my question was more difficult than her answer.”

“Did you explain?”

“Fortunately, I didn’t get the chance.”

Miren finished the seam. The stranger thanked him and left without ever saying who he was.

By the evening of the third day, Miren had left the guardhouse as promised. The guards walked

with him as far as the turn in the road. He said he would spend the night with a ferryman outside the city, whose nets he had helped mend on his way to the palace.

Exactly seven days after their conversation on the bench, the king sent for Miren at the ferryman's house. Miren was asked to return. This time, the king met him in person and offered to make him chief sage.

Miren asked that his old fur coat not be thrown away.

The other sages decided they might soon need it themselves: if the new man could answer everything, why keep the old ones? The king ordered

ceremonial clothes made for him—a robe, a hat, and shoes with upturned toes, as court custom required. They gathered to discuss the commission. At first, each talked about his own pattern without listening to his neighbors. Then one slid a clean sheet of paper into the middle of the table.

“Let’s make him a gift. Not a report.”

They set their cups together, cleared a space, and began inventing things together. One knew plants, another drew animals, a third could hide a puzzle in the turns of a path. A fourth noticed that the sleeve could continue the picture when

the arm was bent. A fifth corrected his calculation—and this time, no one took offense.

A garden, a forest, and little creatures found in no book of animals grew across the emerald-green cloth in gold and silver thread. Every picture hid a riddle. Paths branched, met, and suddenly continued on the far side of a fold.

The sages devoted one of them to the real palace garden. An embroidered gate led to an inconspicuous door by the wall. An old underground passage began there: it ran beneath the ground, out beyond the city, and emerged in a field about twenty kilometers from the palace. The

clothes bore no label saying “emergency exit.” You had to follow the pattern without mistaking the gold branches for the silver road.

When Miren put on the robe, the sages crowded around him, showing him where to find the next part. He asked questions. They answered for one another, corrected themselves, laughed. That evening, no one was superfluous.

Besides the robe, they brought two more gifts.

The second was a small, colorless cube, about five centimeters across. Bright points crowded its faintly cloudy, transparent

depths: some alone, others in groups, with almost empty spaces stretching between them. The sage who studied the heavens handed him a magnifying glass. It was a model of a galaxy—stars and star systems, not real worlds enclosed inside. Miren turned the cube toward the light. Points that had hidden one another separated. He asked them to show him where they had begun building the model.

The third gift was a flat stone bearing the impression of a leaf. Its branching veins had survived so clearly that it seemed the leaf had only just been removed and the stone still remembered where it had lain.

Miren ran a finger beside the impression, without touching the fine grooves.

“What tree did it come from?”

No one answered. That was why the sages had chosen the stone: they wanted to know themselves.

Miren adjusted his robe and set the cube by the window. He laid the stone on the table. That evening, books on plants were brought to him. The next morning, more books.

There were similar leaves among the illustrations, but something was always wrong: the veins branched differently, or the edge was not right. Miren did not choose the closest match simply

to finish the task. He had an exact drawing made and sent it to the six other kingdoms. In his own, they had already gone through everything they could find.

The replies came one at a time, roughly a week apart. The first thanked him for an interesting problem. The second sent a drawing of a different leaf. The third listed books Miren already had open. The fourth admitted plainly that they had no answer.

The fifth arrived after five weeks. Its writer apologized for the delay: the time had been spent not on the plant, but on finding someone who might recognize it. No such people remained at court. The king had other

concerns. The grass was regularly cut to keep the lawns even; that did not require knowing what grew beneath the blade or what use it might have.

Only the seventh kingdom remained—the most distant.

A week later, nothing had arrived from there. Another week passed. Still nothing.

The stone lay on Miren's table for six months. Sometimes the edge of a sheet of paper was laid over it, then moved away. The king needed advice about things other than leaves. Miren listened, asked questions, went to look at whatever he was being told about.

During those months, the king thought more and more often of their first conversation on the bench. He had not followed Miren's advice at once. Several times, he stopped outside his daughter's door and found a reason to return to his duties.

Then, one evening, the king did not summon his daughter for a serious conversation. He went to her himself and asked whether she remembered how her mother had once left her shoes at the palace and spent the whole day walking barefoot in the garden. His daughter remembered something else: a blade of grass caught on her hem. Then she asked whether he missed her.

The king answered.

One evening did not make everything easy. But now, when his daughter remembered her mother, she had someone to go to. Sometimes her father came first. They no longer had to pretend that each had already managed alone.

Miren had almost stopped expecting the last letter.

Nine months passed. At court, nine was called the number of new life; the sages liked to find it wherever something began after a long wait.

The messenger from the distant kingdom had been given a precise deadline: from the day

Miren sent his question, nine months, nine days, and nine nights must pass, followed by nine hours, nine minutes, and nine seconds. The days alternated with the nights, making nine full days. The answer could be delivered neither earlier nor later.

Miren did not yet know this.

When a horn sounded above the gates, very little time remained. The messenger from the seventh kingdom had changed horses a dozen times along the way. He took his last steps without a horse, one hand braced against the wall. The sealed scroll bore the seal of the distant court.

“For Miren,” he said. “At the exact second.”

They caught him. Someone ran for a physician; someone brought water. The messenger would not release the packet until he was sure they were listening.

If the moment was missed, the solution would disappear. Both the person who had written it and the person who had carried it would forget. No archive could restore what still existed now.

Miren was on the far side of the courtyard, by the garden arch. The sages looked at the tower clock. Nine seconds. None of them could run there in time.

A shepherd boy sat beside the steps with a flute. A curly-haired lamb chewed a blade of grass by his foot. The boy had already stood up when he saw the messenger fall.

“Can you run fast?”

“No one has ever beaten me.”

They pointed out Miren and told him the exact second.

The boy ran. The lamb lifted its head but stayed by the steps.

Miren saw the packet and held out his hand.

The boy stopped before him. He did not hand it over.

A hand moved on the clock.

Only then did the packet pass from one hand to the other.

Miren broke the seal and read. He told no one what was written inside. But now he knew about the magical tree.

Later, the king, whose weakness had lingered for so long, could once again walk through the garden without stopping. He paused before a mirror: his face no longer seemed to belong to a man who was merely waiting for the day to end.

“What happened?” he asked Miren.

The sage brought him the stone with the leaf’s impression.

“This stone. The answer came from the last kingdom. The boy delivered it in time.”

“Does he run fast?”

“Yes. But it also helped that he knew when to stop.”

Miren pointed to the clock.

“I was already holding out my hand. He waited.”

An emerald fence was built around the tree. When the sun fell at the right angle, green reflections lay across the trunk and leaves. A gold plaque bore red lettering declaring that the tree belonged not to one state but to all humanity. No one was free to pluck its leaves, break its

branches, or saw through its trunk.

Each time, before taking what was needed, Miren asked the tree's forgiveness. He took so little that a passerby might not have noticed anything.

The method for preparing the medicine was shared with the other kingdoms. A pharmacy opened beside the tree. The elixir was made in small quantities: sometimes a tiny piece of a leaf was enough to help.

The miracle was real, but it promised no identical outcome for everyone. Some recovered; others found relief; for others, it bought time in which help still

had to be found. It did not bring back the dead or make people invulnerable.

People began to live longer. Some of those helped by the medicine would eventually live to five hundred. But no one knew that yet. Sick people still came to the pharmacy. Miren would not allow the words on the plaque to be replaced with a promise to deliver everyone from every misfortune. The tree belonged to everyone; that did not mean it could do everything.

The tree was found and its medicine began to reach people before the palace heard of Tom Brown's performances.

Now the gold path on his sleeve had reached the edge of the real table. Miren stopped beside it, leaning on his staff. He could make out the worry on their faces, but he could not tell where they were all looking.

The king laid the emerald on the table.

“This is an invitation. You will tell me where to go.”

The sages drew closer.

“By sunset,” he added. “If you cannot find the address, I will have you all executed as charlatans.”

The one who had been about to speak first closed his mouth.

The king left.

First, they examined the card over a white cloth. They checked the edges, searched for letters between the letters of the name, counted the flourishes. One sage declared that the absence of an address was itself an instruction not to leave the palace. They asked him what the date was for, then. He asked to be allowed to finish his thought.

Another went to the window.

Through the emerald, the city turned green. Roofs, square, cart by the gate—everything except the gold letters took on the same color. The sage held the card before his eyes.

“There.”

The others rose.

“What?”

He moved the stone along the street. The green city moved with his hand. For a moment, it seemed that another place lay beyond the window, somewhere they could reach if they could work out which roof mattered most.

They took the card from him.

They looked through it at the garden. The grass grew darker. Then at one another’s faces. One sage almost laughed when he saw his neighbor turn green; he

remembered sunset and stopped before making a sound.

Nothing appeared. The city remained a city, the grass remained grass. Brown could fill an empty glass; they expected his stone to do something of the sort, at least.

The oldest held out his hand.

“Let me have a look.”

“In a moment, Miren. Let us just finish looking.”

He lowered his hand. They brought him a chair but set it well away from the window so he would not be in their way.

A book on the properties of emeralds was opened on the

table. Someone suggested heating the card. The others objected: if it cracked, there would be no need to wait until evening. They turned to the next page.

The strip of sunlight on the floor reached a table leg.

“I have spent many years looking at things,” the oldest said. “Perhaps I might see something here as well.”

“The writing is so small.”

“That is why I am asking you to bring it closer.”

At last they handed him the card. The man arguing by the window needed both hands to hold his book open.

The oldest rested the emerald on his palm. Ran a finger along its edge. Moved closer to the light and began turning the card: first away from himself, then a little to one side.

“Please don’t block the light.”

The man standing over him stepped back.

A fine gold line flickered across the green surface.

The oldest returned his hand to its former position. The line disappeared. He turned it again—and it came back, with another, shorter line beside it.

“Look here.”

No one had time to say they already had.

Lines of shoreline were emerging from within the stone. They lay beneath a second, smooth layer of emerald; a fingernail passed over the surface without catching on anything. Held straight before the eyes, the card let them look through it at the whole city. Now the gold had caught the light, and the city no longer mattered most.

The oldest did not try to read the tiny markings.

“Hold it like this,” he told the nearest man.

The man took the card between two fingers and held still.

“That’s a river.”

“The mouth,” another corrected him.

“And here’s the road from the palace.”

They crowded closer, blocking one another’s light, and immediately stepped apart again. A little map lay inside the emerald. The road ended at the old salt wharf.

One of the sages sat down on the floor.

Another sank to his knees before the oldest. Two more followed; soon there was scarcely room around the chair. Their heads bowed almost to the stone slabs.

“Forgive us. We thought so highly of ourselves, and we turned out to be fools. You alone solved it. You saved our lives.”

The oldest was looking for someone to hand his staff to: it lay across his knees and kept him from getting up.

“Please, my friends, rise. There is nothing clever about it. The important thing is perspective.”

One of the kneeling men raised his head. The oldest pointed to the card.

“Pass it to someone whose eyes are better than mine. The address still needs writing down.”

When the king returned, a sheet of paper showing the road to the wharf lay on the table. The sage holding the emerald showed him how to turn it. The king tried for himself. He managed it on the second attempt.

He took back the card and ordered his carriage made ready.

Outside the window, the sun had not yet touched the roofs. The sages gathered their books in silence; now each checked to make sure no one else's magnifying glass or staff had been left among his things.

In another palace, a pigeon was taken to the kitchen first.

They were the quickest to realize it was tame. They gave it water, but instead of drinking it dragged its case after it until it had their attention. It was brought to the king on a tray, along with the card, which had already been removed. The tray was silver; the pigeon was wet on one side. It had managed to tip over the saucer after all.

The king was waiting by the window. He told everyone to leave.

His name and a date were engraved on a thin plate of aquamarine. He read them standing up, then held it in a sunbeam opposite the bed, and a pale blue patch ran across the

white wall. The edges trembled with his hand; the middle was almost clear.

“Is that the sea?” the girl asked.

“No. A stone.”

“Why is it moving?”

He steadied his wrist with his other hand. The patch stopped.

“Because I’m holding it.”

She watched for only a little while. Then she turned back to her pillow, and he wanted to say something else—something that would make her look up again. There was not a word about her in the invitation. He looked again at his own name and the date, then turned the stone over, as

though an answer might be on the other side.

They had already tried the magic tree's elixir. The girl felt better for it, but her illness did not go away.

A letter from her grandfather lay on the bedside table. The eastern king offered to send two doctors who were independent of the court's routine; if necessary, the girl could be moved somewhere people would not be brought in every morning to assure themselves that the heir was thriving. The letter did not claim the doctors would certainly help. It proposed letting them try.

The girl's mother came in without knocking. At the door she paused

to let a woman carrying a basin pass, then moved the empty chair to the bedside herself.

“Can the reply go today?” she asked.

The king covered the letter with his hand.

“I haven’t finished reading it.”

She did not remind him when it had arrived. She sat down and smoothed a turned-back edge of the pillowcase. The girl moved her own head and settled her cheek on the cool patch.

“Is Grandfather coming?” she asked.

“He’s offering to send doctors,” her mother said.

“But is he coming?”

The king turned the stone. Blue light returned to the wall, but the girl was looking at her mother.

“I’ll ask him,” he said.

His wife reached for the letter. He moved his hand. She read only the lower part, where they were to say when the doctors could arrive, then put the sheet on the little table before him.

“I’ll have the rooms beside ours cleared. They won’t need to go through the reception room.”

“Not yet.”

“Why?”

He looked at their daughter. She was trying to flatten a fold in the blanket; something inside it was catching against her heel. Her mother lifted the edge, and the girl stretched out her leg.

“Not here,” the king said.

His wife stood. He picked up the letter and followed her. In the next room he left the door not quite shut.

“I want to know what they intend to do first.”

“Then write and ask. They’ll answer.”

A traveling writing case stood on the table by the door. She opened it. The pen lay apart from the ink,

wrapped in paper to protect its point. The king unwrapped it and set the paper beside the case.

“What if they say she must be taken away?”

“We’ll be here. So will she. You can ask them yourself.”

He squared the letter with the edge of the table. There was plenty of room for his signature.

Their daughter called for her mother. His wife went back, leaving the case open.

The king held the pen by its far end. Then he looked at the aquamarine still in his other hand and wrapped the pen in its paper again. The card bore a date.

He checked it against the calendar by the door and took the letter with him.

When he returned to the bedside, his wife was in the same chair. Their daughter had stopped smoothing the blanket.

“Are you going away?” the girl asked.

“Not for long.”

“Then leave that here.”

He looked at the card.

“I need it to get in.”

The girl nodded. She did not ask again.

He set the stone on the edge of her blanket for another minute.

This time he did not have to hold it. The patch of light moved slowly on its own, with the sun.

When he picked the card up from the blanket, the aquamarine turned edge-on toward the window. A gold line flashed inside. The king held his hand still, then turned the stone a little farther. Beneath the smooth surface appeared the road from his palace, a bend in the river and the salt warehouses. He recognized the wharf.

He bent to show the girl, but she had already closed her eyes. The king put the card in its case.

The eastern king had help from his secretary. Moving a lamp to

read the date on the amethyst more easily, the man noticed a bend in a road appear and vanish inside the stone. They put the lamp back and checked the drawing against an ordinary town plan.

The king with the broad ring asked a jeweler to value the pink tourmaline. Examining the edge, the man noticed two joined layers. He did not try to separate them: he tilted the card toward the light and showed the gold between them. The king asked about the price again, after he had been told where the wharf was.

The quiet king laid the rock crystal against his dark sleeve to

make out his own name. When he turned his wrist toward the lamp, lines emerged beneath the letters. He shaded the map from the direct light with his palm and spent a long while looking at the shore where the road ended.

The king in the dark coat examined both faces of the topaz, then its edges. He disliked the suggestion that Brown had left the invitation unfinished. He kept turning the stone until one of the lines inside caught the light. Then he fetched a harbor plan himself, without telling the servant why he wanted it.

The gray-haired king’s younger brother found the map while playing with his citrine card by a

window. Yellow light fell first on his palm, then on his cuff. At one angle, a golden road appeared inside. He returned the card to that position and called for someone who knew the streets better than he did.

By the appointed date, all seven knew where the old salt wharf was. None of the maps showed an island.

Brown’s puppet box was being made ready for travel too.

His assistant, Antonio Gonzalez, laid the control bars along its rim and checked that no string would catch beneath the lid. He had to turn the puppet with the cracked cheek: her elbow prevented

another from fitting beside her. He lifted the elbow by its string. Her shoulder sank a little inside the costume.

Antonio lowered his hand and adjusted the lining.

“There,” he said.

Then he went to find a strap.

The puppet waited until he had gone. Her control bar lay still, but she freed her own hand from beneath another puppet’s leg. It hurt to bend the arm all the way. She turned her whole body to make room for the elbow.

Her neighbor in striped trousers lay across her feet. A little bundle was still inside his cuff. She felt its

edge with a fingertip without taking it out: the cloth was in place. Then she drew her own string toward her. Now she could rise without dragging him after her.

A thin strip of light fell through the partly open door onto the lining.

She put a foot into it. Took a step, then paused as though someone stood before her whom she ought to let pass. She held out an arm toward the empty space, waited, and drew back a little. Nobody was there, yet the way she stepped aside made it plain that her guest had passed without so much as thanking her.

Onstage, people laughed at this.

Brown lifted the control bar; she supplied the pause, the hurt feelings, and the little bow that followed. His hand was not above her now. The strip of light was too narrow: she could not bow without knocking the head beside her.

She sat down and moved her neighbor's foot off the fold Antonio had straightened.

The footsteps returned. She lay down with her good arm along her side.

Antonio lowered the lid and threaded the strap through its buckle. The box rose and tilted; wooden bodies slid toward one

wall. The puppet slipped her palm beneath another’s cheek before it struck the edge.

Outside, someone tested the fastening.

The old salt wharf smelled of wet hemp and empty barrels.

No one had posted guards along the road. This was discovered at once and caused more displeasure than the absence of music. The arriving retinues stopped where the paved street ended; beyond it ran a narrow strip of planking where even two people could only pass by turning sideways.

The seventh king arrived too early. He had time to walk to the

end of the wharf and back twice. A table stood beside the gangplank, and on it a wooden box with seven compartments. An attendant held the cards made from different stones up to the light to check them, then returned them to their owners. He kept none.

“Will he be there to meet us?” the seventh king asked.

“You will be given his reply on the island.”

“I’m asking about meeting him.”

The attendant merely bowed. The seventh king put his card away and stepped aside, unwilling to pursue the matter for another bow instead of an answer.

There had been too many bows at his coronation, too. Some of those who had bowed lowest had soon refused to recognize his seal. In two cities, windows were already being smashed in houses that displayed his flag. If Brown would stand beside him on even one balcony, it would be harder for the doubters to say there was no real king.

The card did not promise that, either.

When he saw the gray-haired king, the seventh went to meet him, then almost immediately stopped to let the older man go first through the narrow passage. The gray-haired king took his elbow without thinking, helping

him step over a gap between the boards.

“I can see it,” the younger said.

“You could see it last time, too.”

The seventh king gave a small shrug but did not pull his arm away. They reached the table together.

The last to step out of his carriage was the king who had mostly kept silent before. His luggage consisted of one flat suitcase, a whitish streak of salt across its leather lid. The king with the broad ring went up to him, held out his hand, and asked about his daughter.

“She writes that your son has ordered her conservatory rebuilt,” the quiet king replied.

“She was cold in it.”

“Good that it can be rebuilt.”

The king with the ring did not understand what he meant. He was about to ask when the attendant addressed them all.

“The ship will take seven guests. No retinues. The voyage to the island takes seven days. Maps and navigational instruments will remain here, in sealed storage. The question of a performance will be settled when you arrive.”

He asked each guest to check his traveling case for maps,

compasses, and optical instruments with graduated scales.

“Watches, too?” asked the eastern king.

“You may keep your watches. Nobody requires you to forget the time.”

Two pocket compasses, a rolled map, and a small instrument in a leather case appeared on the table. The king in the dark coat took another thin sheet from a book. He started to fold it back in, then opened it and laid it with the rest.

“A plan of the harbors,” he explained.

“That, too.”

“And these?” The seventh king held up his stone card.

“Keep those with you. They show only the way to the wharf, not the route to the island.”

The attendant did not search their pockets. The objects were placed in the compartments. Each king could add his own seal; the king with the ring did so, first asking for fresh wax. Receipts were carried back to the carriages. The storage box was staying on the wharf, not traveling with the ship.

“Will we be blindfolded?” the seventh king asked.

The captain, who had been watching the loading, turned.

“What for?”

“So we won’t see the way.”

“Look as much as you like. You’re not to record courses or soundings to find your way back. If you don’t agree, you may stay ashore. We have another quarter of an hour before we leave.”

He pointed to the open gangplank, then added:

“I’ll take you there and back. What you do on the island is up to you.”

The gray-haired king still held his folded traveling cloak. He glanced back at the carriage. The

secretary stood by its door with his portfolio, ready to approach if called.

The king did not call.

Once all seven were aboard, the gangplank was not removed at once. A sailor went back for a forgotten basket; another handed empty containers ashore. Ordinary business went on for a few more minutes. No one hurried the guests or announced that there was no turning back.

Then a wet rope slid across the wood.

The seventh king was the first to wave to those on the wharf. The gray-haired king did not wave. The king by the window was

looking into his case: had he chipped the stone by putting it away too hastily? Nothing was broken.

A narrow strip of water opened between the hull and the planks.

It widened without any magic at all.

In the margins: 1 · 2 · 3 · 4 · 5 · 6 · 7 · 8

2. No Shore

On the first day, the kings kept getting up.

One of them would rise from the table to look at the shore, and the others would find reasons to go out as well. The shore was still visible: a strip of land above which a bell tower appeared and disappeared. After the ship turned, it was on the other side, and the king with the ring remarked that they seemed to be going back.

The captain said they were rounding a shoal.

“You’ve sailed here before?”

“Yes.”

“Often?”

The captain looked at the sail, then back at the king.

“Often enough.”

He did not invite them to the wheel, but he did not send them away. For a while all seven watched nothing in particular happen. Water passed along the hull; the sail pulled taut, then softened into a fold. The shore grew lower. By the time they returned to the table, the soup was cold.

By evening the gray-haired king had stopped getting up.

He sat near the rail, very straight, his hands on his knees. Someone suggested he go down to his cabin; he replied that the air was better here. When the ship rose on a long swell, he shut his eyes.

His younger brother brought him a mug.

“No.”

“It isn’t for you. Hold it.”

The gray-haired king took the mug. His brother sat down beside him as though he meant to take it back immediately, but instead began fiddling with the buckle on his own boot. The water in the mug was warm and slightly tart. The gray-haired king took a sip.

“What is this?”

“Ask the cook.”

His brother unbuckled his boot after all, though there was no need. The gray-haired king reached down to loosen his own, then stopped: bending over was worse than sitting still.

His brother silently crouched in front of him.

“I can do it.”

“Bend down, then.”

The gray-haired king looked at the dark crown of his head. It had been a long time since he had seen it from this angle. His brother loosened the buckle, shifted the cloak away from a wet

patch on the boards, and returned to the bench.

“Don’t tell anyone,” the older king said.

“Tell whom?”

“Anyone.”

“That you drink water?”

The gray-haired king looked away. After a while he handed back the empty mug.

Their dinner was brought out to them. They ate without a table, balancing plates on their knees. At every swell, the younger brother lifted his plate slightly higher than necessary; twice the gray-haired king was about to

correct him, and both times he stopped himself.

On the second morning, the shore was gone.

Now it turned out that a ship made sounds you could not hear by the wharf: a short knock beneath the planking, a long creak overhead, a sailor’s step recognizable not by its weight but by the place where he always stepped over a board. The king in the dark coat woke to something rolling on the other side of the wall and waited a long time for someone to put it away. Then he found his own shaving box under his bunk.

He was late for breakfast. Nobody reproached him, which somehow irritated him more than a question would have.

The cook served a rectangular cake with a dark cherry filling. The king with the ring received a corner piece, where the chocolate was thickest. He turned his plate, chose the best edge, and had just raised his fork when a masked face appeared from behind a coil of rope.

The paw arrived before anyone could stop it.

A crumb remained on the fork.

Raccoon leaped off the crate, clutching his prize, and vanished

behind a barrel. There was a light clatter, then nothing.

“Food is being stolen aboard His Majesty’s ship! What unsanitary conditions!” the king exclaimed.

The cook looked at the plate, then at the king, as though trying to establish which majesty had acquired the ship overnight.

“I’ll bring another slice.”

“It isn’t about the slice.”

“A fresh plate, then.”

The quiet king coughed into his napkin. His daughter’s father-in-law turned toward him, but he was already looking out to sea. The second plate arrived with a cover. The king was about

to refuse it, then lifted the cover and made sure the new piece was also a corner.

No one asked about Raccoon again.

After breakfast it grew hot. The sailors stretched an awning above the table, but one corner kept flapping. The eastern king, who was sitting beneath it, held the canvas while a sailor went for a rope. Then he noticed that the loose end could be passed around the other side of the upright.

“Hand that here,” he told the king in the dark coat.

The king handed it over.

The king by the window stood to let him through between the bench and the table. The gray-haired king moved a heavy basket. The quiet king held the edge while the younger brother took the rope around the upright. The king with the ring picked up the mugs, which would otherwise have tipped over, and set them on the deck.

It took less than a minute.

When the sailor returned, the corner was no longer flapping. He checked the knot, added another turn, and said:

“That’ll hold now.”

The seven sat down. It was noticeably cooler in the shade.

“If only we could do that with the eastern passage,” the eastern king said.

He said it almost without thinking, still looking at the secured corner.

The king in the dark coat stopped pouring water.

“Which one, exactly?”

“You know which one.”

“Then it would be better to name it.”

The eastern king hesitated. He could have said that his men had detained the supply wagons, although the agreement required them to let them through. He could have proposed admitting

joint observers before the troops began moving. Instead, he started with how much effort it had taken to establish peace at all.

The king with the ring nodded. The gray-haired king looked at the basket he had just moved.

“When I first brought you together,” the eastern king said, “many thought it impossible even to sit at one table. Now we have at least learned—”

“It was your men who held the wagons,” said the king in the dark coat.

“I was just coming to the details.”

“It isn’t a detail to the people waiting for flour.”

The eastern king laid both palms on the edge of the table. Beneath him lay the shade they had made together.

“If that’s the tone you prefer, let’s leave this for another time.”

Nobody asked him to continue. The wind freshened, and the canvas above them tightened with a soft sound.

That evening, the eastern king took an order from his traveling folder. A space had been left at the bottom for the final signature. Whether he put it there would determine whether his grown son led men toward the passage when the agreement expired.

He ran a fingernail along the fold. The paper was already worn there.

No mail was being sent from the ship. But before sailing he had had time either to sign or to revoke his previous instructions. Now he reread the order as though indecision could add a few days to the deadline.

On the third day, the king by the window asked for ink.

They brought him a small traveling inkstand with a heavy base. The table rocked slightly; the ink did not spill, but he had to hold his pen above the page, waiting for the right movement.

The eastern king did not sit opposite him at once.

“May I?”

The king shifted his folder to make room.

The letter about the doctors was out of its envelope. In the blank margin he had already written: “I give permission.” He still needed to say to whom, when, and with what authority. He could finish it now and send it back at the first opportunity.

“They’ll travel without an entourage,” the eastern king said. “I wrote that. And there will be no report to the council. The doctors will speak to you and her mother.”

“You wrote that she ought to be taken away.”

“I wrote: if necessary.”

“From her own home.”

“From a room twenty people pass through every day.”

“I don’t need your council at her bedside,” he said.

“There will be two doctors. Not a council.”

“And afterward they’ll ask why I didn’t call them myself before.”

The eastern king looked at him.

The king hurriedly moved the inkstand: it was too close to the edge. This time the roll of the ship had not spilled a drop.

The king lowered his pen.

The eastern king looked at him, then at the few words he had written. In these three days he had not once asked about the girl in front of the others. His silence could be taken for discretion or for calculation. The king always chose the second explanation, because it made it easier not to thank him.

“She asked about you,” he said suddenly.

The eastern king’s face changed.

“What did she ask?”

“When you were coming. Not the doctors. You.”

“I’ll come.”

The king picked up his pen again. The ink had already thickened on its point.

“I would like to speak to Brown first.”

“Has he told you he can heal people?”

“He says very little about what he can do.”

“That isn’t an answer.”

“I know.”

He said the words quietly, almost angrily. The eastern king did not repeat his question. For a while they sat so close that the king could simply have passed the letter across the table.

Then he folded it with the blank side facing up.

The pen remained beside it. He did not ask anyone to take the ink away.

That afternoon, the king in the dark coat noticed a movement overhead and stepped sharply away from the mast.

A little lizard was climbing the wood. It carried a thin stick in its teeth and had to stop several times when the stick caught on rough patches. Reaching a ledge by the yardarm, it settled on its hind legs, took the stick in its forefeet, and held it out like a spear.

The king ducked.

The stick was as long as his finger.

The gray-haired king looked up, then at the ducking man.

“Present your terms,” he said.

The king in the dark coat straightened and adjusted his collar. The ledge was empty now: the lizard had gone around the other side of the mast with its weapon.

For the first time on the voyage, the gray-haired king laughed. His younger brother laughed after him. The king in the dark coat waited until they had finished, then smiled too—reluctantly, with one corner of his mouth.

Later, the king by the window went over to his cousin. He waited for the others to move away, then asked:

“And how is yours?”

The king did not pretend to misunderstand.

“Alive.”

“Does he write?”

He nodded.

“Then you can answer him.”

“It isn’t that simple.”

A long branch floated past the hull. They both followed it until it disappeared beyond the stern.

“He’s stubborn,” said the king by the window. “Remember when he wouldn’t come down from the roof? He was twelve. Everyone else had gone, and there he sat.”

“He isn’t on a roof now.”

“I know.”

The king in the dark coat took out a letter. He did not hand it over, only unfolded it as though intending to show one line. In it his grown son wrote: “If you withdraw the soldiers and let the people leave safely, I will come of my own accord. To talk, not to be taken into custody.”

His cousin had time to read it.

“He wants to come back.”

“He wants me to—”

The king fell silent. The paper stirred in the wind. He pinned it with his thumb.

“To do what?”

“To admit that he chose to stay with them.”

For a few moments the words remained between them, uncorrected.

Then the king folded the sheet.

“But surely you understand the circumstances in which abducted people write.”

His cousin looked at his hand.

Both had come too close to hearing an answer to a question of their own. So neither went on.

That night the ship sailed steadily. Small unsecured objects occasionally clinked in the cabins. The ink on the table was still uncovered; by morning a thin skin had formed on its surface.

In the margins: 9 · 10 · 11 · 12 · 13 · 14

3. The Seventh Day

By the fourth day, each man had a place no one had assigned him.

The gray-haired king sat nearer the middle of the ship, where it rolled less. His brother liked the stern, where he could watch the wake slowly become indistinguishable from the rest of the sea. The king by the window had found a corner of the deck with enough light to read by and no wind to snatch his papers. The eastern king no longer sat beside him there, though there was room for two.

The quiet king usually stood.

He was not watching the horizon. What interested him was the water right beside the hull: how it rose, paused for an instant against the wood, and withdrew. After lunch, the king with the ring joined him, rested his elbows on the rail, and asked whether he did not get bored looking at the same thing.

“It isn’t the same thing,” the quiet king replied.

The other shrugged.

“It is to me.”

“We used to think so, too.”

He took his hand from the rail. Salt clung to his palm.

For a while neither spoke. Then the king with the ring asked about the road from the harbor to the royal residence: he had heard it had needed moving.

“The road,” the quiet king clarified. “The house is still standing.”

“Was much swept away?”

“The sea doesn’t take everything at once. That would be easier to understand.”

He pointed to the seam between two boards.

“First, this much. Over a winter. Then more. You order more stone brought in. The stone goes. You move the road, and everyone says

it’s safe to live there now. Only a year later, the road is right beside the water again.”

His daughter’s father-in-law listened without interrupting. The quiet king rubbed his palm along the rail, wiping away the salt, and suddenly began speaking faster.

In the lower village, people were already taking the doors off their houses. The houses themselves were not worth moving, but the doors were. Neighbors were no longer leaving together: some went to relatives, others wherever they could find work. He had ordered families counted, not carts, but people did not always report before departing.

In the government office, the map still showed the church in the middle of a neighborhood. Now it could be approached from only one side.

“Correct the map,” said the king with the ring.

The quiet king turned to him.

“And then?”

The other did not answer at once.

“We have room for people. Inland. We could put them somewhere for the time being.”

He said it without witnesses, and without a request attached. The quiet king looked at him longer than people usually look before saying thank you.

“On what terms?”

“The usual ones. We can arrange a tax exemption while they get settled. Your daughter will help. It will be easier for her—”

“Whose subjects would they become?”

The king with the ring took his elbows off the rail.

“If they settle in our country, ours. Is that really the point just now?”

The quiet king lowered his eyes. It was a genuine offer. Neither his daughter nor the doors lifted off their hinges would be worse off because future documents bore a different seal.

“Temporarily,” he said.

“We can discuss how long.”

“I mean the land. Its administration. So my people don’t find themselves—”

He did not finish. The other waited, then asked carefully:

“Without you?”

The quiet king returned his gaze to the water.

“Scattered.”

After that, they stopped talking about resettlement. The king with the ring said his son was spending more and more time with the garrison commanders. He had to: the other claimant was

sending letters, promising men they could keep their ranks, and some were answering. At family dinners, seats now stood empty that had once been closest to the host.

“Your daughter is with him,” he said. “You understand what will happen if they start dividing up the palace.”

The quiet king nodded.

“Let someone settle it before they start.”

“Who?”

“People both sides would trust. We could provide guarantees. Install joint administrators for a time.”

“My son doesn’t need an administrator.”

“I’m talking about the country, not him.”

The king with the ring raised a hand to his collar, though it was not tight.

“They’re offering to give him what is his as a favor. Do you understand? First they take away what is his by right, then hand it back under someone else’s signature.”

“If his right is beyond dispute—”

“It is beyond dispute.”

They both fell silent.

Behind them, a sailor was sluicing the deck with a bucket. The water reached their boots, and the kings stepped aside together to give him room.

“Things will be clearer after the meeting,” said the king with the ring.

The quiet king did not ask what a meeting with a man who had promised neither land nor arbitration would make clear. He himself hoped to discover something on the island that was missing from the offer he had just received.

On the fifth day, there was washing.

A line was strung where nobody would previously have noticed any room. Towels hung from it, and shirts, and a very long white strip of cloth that had been wrapped around a pitcher's broken handle. The king with the ring disliked seeing his linen beside the sailors'. He was going to ask for it to be moved, but from a distance he could not tell which shirt was his.

With his brother's help, the gray-haired king was wringing out his wet cloak. It had been left by the rail by mistake and soaked by spray in the night. A servant offered to do it, but the brothers had already taken opposite ends.

“The other way,” the gray-haired king said.

“I am twisting the other way.”

“You’re twisting my way.”

The younger brother changed his grip. More water streamed from the cloak. Drops pattered on the boards between their boots.

The gray-haired king remembered the wet blankets spread across roofs. They lasted a little while. Then other blankets were needed, other people, and water that grew harder and harder to bring.

“Is your crossing by the mills open?” he asked.

His brother looked up.

“For whom?”

“Wagons.”

“Yes.”

They spread the cloak out. His brother was going to hang it beside the upright, but the gray-haired king pointed to a place with more wind.

“How many people?” his brother asked.

The gray-haired king realized there was no need to explain.

“I don’t know how many there’ll be by the time we get back.”

“Write to the officer at the crossing from the island. I’ll sign the order to open the stores along

the road. Send it under your seal. He knows it."

The gray-haired king ran his hand over the cloth, smoothing a crease.

"So my people come to you for bread."

"So they eat."

"I understand."

"Then write."

His brother took a clothespin out of his mouth. Before fastening the edge of the cloak, he turned it twice between his fingers—the way he had turned a bone game piece as a child, waiting for his turn. The gray-haired king took another pin from him.

“I’ll see what can be done.”

His brother did not demand a promise. He knew himself how hard it was to accept help after which someone might say the king had only held on thanks to his relatives.

When they had hung the cloak, he caught his brother’s sleeve.

“You will say something in front of him, won’t you?”

“Say what?”

“That people can deal with me. That our houses recognize my claim. Coming from you, it would sound different.”

The gray-haired king eased his brother's fingers off his sleeve, one at a time.

"The hearings aren't over yet."

"By the time they're over, I'll have nobody left."

"You could agree to a joint council. And give them guarantees that you won't change everything at once."

"So they recognize me only until the next vote?"

His brother looked at the hanging cloak. The wind pressed it against the line; for a moment it seemed as though someone were standing behind it.

“If Brown receives me with the rest of you, they won’t be able to pretend it never happened.”

“He invited seven.”

“Exactly.”

The gray-haired king wanted to say that a journey to Brown did not settle disputes over power. But then he would have had to explain what he himself expected from this journey. He straightened a crooked clothespin and went away.

By the sixth day, the sea damp had reached things that had never been taken out of the suitcases.

The kings opened them, rearranged shirts, and dried letters between the pages of books. The stone cards had not grown damp. Not a single gold letter had flaked off. The king by the window held his up to the light, but there was nowhere aboard to cast a patch of blue where the girl could see it. He put the stone away before anyone noticed.

After dinner, the younger brother asked the captain whether they would arrive tomorrow.

“Tomorrow.”

“Are we close now?”

The captain pointed to the water. Long, smooth streaks lay across

it, which the guests had taken for cloud shadows.

“The current has changed. We’ll be turning soon.”

They waited almost an hour for the turn. At last the ship leaned a little, a sail passed over the deck, and the sunset was no longer in its familiar place.

Nothing else happened.

None of the seven went straight to bed.

They saw the island on the seventh morning.

At first they took it for a low cloud. Then the cloud stayed where it was while the others drifted behind it, and a dark line

appeared along its edge. By noon they could distinguish trees, pale ledges above the water, and the narrow entrance to a bay. The houses appeared later: not on the summit, as the kings had expected, but a little above the wharf, among the greenery.

Not a single flag flew above the bay.

The ship slowed. The sailors were doing what they had done on the day of departure, only in reverse: bringing out ropes, preparing the gangplank, checking that the cargo was not in the way. It was more reassuring than any ceremonial welcome could have been.

A man in a light frock coat was waiting ashore. He addressed each guest by his title without consulting a paper. The seventh king turned slightly to make sure the others had heard.

“Your rooms are ready,” the man said. “Your luggage will be brought up. Once you’ve rested, someone will show you to the common hall.”

“And Brown?” asked the king with the ring.

“You will be given his letter.”

“Are we being asked to write again?”

Their greeter did not answer for his employer. Instead, he pointed to the ship.

“It sails back tomorrow after noon. If anyone wishes to leave, simply tell us here, or tell the captain. No tickets are required.”

The gray-haired king stopped before stepping ashore.

“Even if we don’t stay for the performance?”

“Yes. Your passage back does not depend on that.”

“The ship will wait in the bay?”

“Until tomorrow’s departure.”

The captain, standing beside the gangplank, confirmed the time.

Then he asked them to clear the way: their suitcases were being carried off behind them.

The house was not far. Two gardeners carrying a ladder came toward them along the path. They laid it on the grass to let the seven pass. The king by the window glanced back; beyond the bend, he could still see the mast and the pale strip of the gangplank.

The doors to the rooms opened with ordinary handles. On every little table stood a pitcher, with a clean towel beside it. The quiet king went straight to his window and checked how far below him the water was. The ledge was high. For now, the shore here was holding firm.

They did not arrive in the common hall together.

The gray-haired king took a little longer to change. His younger brother waited in the corridor and, when the door opened, silently handed him the dry cloak. The older man took it by the collar; the cloth still held the stiffness of salt.

Seven identical armchairs stood in the hall.

A sealed envelope lay in the middle of the table. Their greeter stepped back, making room for the guests. Through the open door they could see the corridor, and at the end of the corridor, daylight.

The eastern king was the last to sit down. He put his traveling folder beside his chair, where he would not step on it if he had to get up.

The gray-haired king picked up the letter.

Beneath the seal, the paper was perfectly dry.

4. They Could Leave

The gray-haired king passed the envelope to the eastern king, who broke the seal.

Until then, the letter had lain between seven glasses of water. There was nothing on the envelope but an address to them all. Each still had his own card, made from a different stone; here, inside the closed room, no sunlight passed through them. They looked darker than they had at sea.

The eastern king unfolded the sheet. He read the opening aloud and stopped.

“Go on,” said the king with the broad ring.

He finished reading.

Then they read the letter again.

Brown proposed that they choose one of the seven, kill him, cook him, and eat him. The survivors would divide his lands among themselves. There would be six of them. He liked six better than seven, and once they had fulfilled his conditions, he might agree to perform.

The gray-haired king held out his hand. They passed him the letter. He went back to the middle, then to the beginning, as though the terrible line might depend on a word he had missed.

“There is a mistake.”

The eastern king did not ask where.

No mistake could be found.

The gray-haired king put the letter down. His younger brother, sitting opposite, carefully moved a glass away from the paper. He had done that since childhood: first save whatever was on the table from spilled water, then decide whether it needed saving.

“Might?” said the man with the ring.

“That is not the word that should concern us,” the gray-haired king replied.

“All the words concern me. That one too.”

The king by the window looked at the envelope. The signature was genuine. The seal had been broken in front of them all. No one could say the letter had gone astray on the journey or been exchanged for another before they sailed: it had been delivered here, in their host’s name, after all seven had entered the room.

Someone knocked.

The gray-haired king turned so sharply that the servant stopped on the threshold.

“The captain asked me to confirm,” he said. “The ship sails

back tomorrow afternoon. How many places should we prepare?”

No one answered.

“All seven are still available,” the servant added. “If you wish. He only asked to be told about the luggage.”

“Can we go down now?” asked the gray-haired king.

“Of course. Down the stairs to the right, then through the garden. They are preparing the cabins already.”

The servant had not looked at the letter. He was waiting for an ordinary instruction, and the gray-haired king suddenly felt

how easy it would be to give him exactly that.

Seven places. Seven people. No reason to count again.

“Wait in the corridor,” said the eastern king. “We shall need to send a reply to our host.”

The servant went out, leaving the door ajar.

“We will send it back,” said the king with the ring.

The gray-haired king nodded.

“Of course.”

“Let him explain himself.”

“No. We simply refuse.”

After those words, breathing became easier. Beyond the window they could see the edge of the quay; a mast showed between the trees. The ship had not vanished.

“All of us,” the gray-haired king added.

His brother was the first to nod, but when the eastern king drew a blank sheet toward him, he lowered his eyes.

“What shall I write?”

“That the conditions are unacceptable.”

“And we are leaving.”

“And there will be no performance.”

The king by the window turned his head.

“Not for us.”

The eastern king kept his palm on the paper.

“What distinction are you making?”

The formality had gone from his voice. This was how he spoke to his daughter’s husband when no one else was there to hear.

The other did not answer at once.

“He may receive someone later.”

“Let him,” said the gray-haired king. “There are enough people in the world who would never think

of eating one another for a ticket.”

“I am not talking about a ticket.”

The eastern king looked at him, and the king by the window looked away. A white edge showed beneath his cuff: the letter he had moved from place to place several times during the journey. No signature had appeared at the bottom.

“The doctors are still willing to come,” the eastern king said quietly.

“Not here.”

“We can send your permission on the ship. They need not know what was in this envelope.”

The king by the window drew out the letter. He had meant to tuck it farther in, but pulled it all the way out. The paper was worn at the fold; his daughter's name stood above the middle, and he covered it with his thumb.

"At your house, the first thing they will do is declare her ill."

"She is ill at yours too."

The man in the dark coat pushed a glass toward his cousin. His cousin pushed it away too hard. Water splashed over the rim.

"I am not refusing the doctors," he said. "I want to speak to him first."

The gray-haired king turned Brown's letter so that its opening faced him.

"He has not promised to heal anyone."

"I can see that."

"He has not even promised to hear you."

The king by the window blotted the water with his handkerchief. It took him far too long to soak up the small puddle.

"The man who saw the water did not invent it," he said at last. "And you saw it yourself."

"A glass is not a child."

"I know."

He said it so fiercely that the gray-haired king fell silent. But the king by the window did not sign the letter to the doctors. He folded it in half and put it away more carefully this time, with the dry side against his body.

The eastern king brought the sheet for their refusal closer still.

“None of us must receive him alone if we leave now.”

“What if he comes of his own accord?” asked the man with the ring.

“You will not receive him.”

“Even if he wishes to apologize?”

The gray-haired king leaned back.

“He can apologize in writing.”

“He can. But if a man comes to your house, you are entitled to ask what he meant.”

“And ask him to stand beside your son on the balcony,” said the previously silent king.

The father of his daughter’s husband turned quickly toward him.

“You know perfectly well what is happening.”

“I do. My daughter lives in the same house.”

“Then do not speak of it that way.”

Both fell silent. They could have returned, here and now, to the proposal from the related courts: transfer part of the authority to a joint council while the dispute lasted, guarantee the safety of both claimants, and wait for their rights of succession to be examined. The papers for that required neither a miracle nor another man's death. The man with the ring had himself dictated the rejection of such a council. Now he pressed his ring against the tabletop as though setting a seal in wax that was still soft.

"My son is not a petitioner," he said.

"Then let us not write about him for the moment," the eastern king

intervened. “Let us write about ourselves.”

He picked up the pen.

The gray-haired king waited for the first letter. The pen, however, remained above the page.

“If we are all agreed,” the eastern king added.

“We shall be agreed when each of us says no.”

The man in the dark coat, who had so far avoided touching the letter, stirred.

“And shall we say no at home too? To the troops, the advisers, the people who have already sent out orders?”

“At home we shall have to talk to people.”

“My son is with people one cannot talk to.”

The king by the window raised tired eyes to his cousin.

“He wrote to you. He told you on what conditions he would come.”

“It is easy for you to judge.”

“No.”

“As long as they are holding him…”

He broke off. A few days earlier, on the ship, that word had already proved too narrow. His son was a grown man. He had stayed of his own free will and

demanded the withdrawal of troops, a safe meeting, and a promise not to punish those who came with him. The letter grew no less clear because his father kept it apart from the official reports.

“That is not what we are discussing,” said the king in the dark coat.

“It is,” the gray-haired king replied. “What we shall have to go back to.”

He looked at his brother. At last the younger man met his eyes.

“I need at least to be received as an equal,” he said. “Once, before witnesses. Then they will stop

saying at home that my reign is only temporary."

"You could let them take part in examining the claims."

"They want to take my rights away."

"Not all of them."

"You do not know how much I have already conceded."

The gray-haired king knew it was not everything. At their last meeting, his brother had shown him a list of demands. Beside one—a restriction on appointments made by the king alone—stood a small cross. It could be struck out, and the discussion begun again.

“I will go with you,” the gray-haired king said.

His brother looked at him with sudden hope.

“And tell them I am right?”

“I will sit beside you and listen.”

The hope disappeared before the younger man could hide his face.

The eastern king put down the pen. The blank sheet remained blank.

“What is happening to us?” asked the gray-haired king. “He is telling us to kill a man. All seven of us are sitting here now, and we can simply say no.”

He stood.

His chair slid across the floor. At the door he paused for a moment, expecting his brother to rise too. His brother was looking at his citrine card.

“If you decide to refuse, send word to the ship.”

He opened the door. The servant stepped aside to let him pass. There was daylight at the end of the corridor, and the smell of the sea.

“Shall I have your luggage taken down, Your Majesty?”

“Yes,” said the gray-haired king.

It was the first decision that day to be carried out.

He left the room and reached the stairs. Two people were carrying linen across the lower landing. When they saw him, they pressed themselves against the wall, and he told them to go on. His voice sounded ordinary.

The report of the fire was in his pocket. He took it out, although he knew the final line: get the people across the border before the wind changed. The water that had come earlier had saved some of the wells, but had not stopped the dry forest burning. The commander of the border post was asking permission to appeal to their neighbors in the king’s name; the families could not be left beside the road.

The gray-haired king could have written his permission on the back and sent it with the first ship returning. He imagined his seal being broken at another court. They would read his request to take in his subjects. Ask how many there were. Begin deciding where to settle them.

Laughter came from below. The people carrying the linen had already passed the stairs.

Nothing could be heard from the council room.

The gray-haired king did not return at once. First he folded the report, then opened it again: too sharp a crease had begun to tear the line containing the village’s

name. He smoothed it with his finger. He wanted to know what names were being spoken behind the door that had closed.

When he came in, his brother looked up.

“I am staying so that you cannot call my silence consent,” the gray-haired king said.

No one argued. His chair was empty.

After a while the servant brought more water and said the luggage would be taken down. The gray-haired king nodded. He did not cancel the instruction.

“How much land will there be to divide?” asked the king in the dark coat.

The gray-haired king looked sharply at him.

“I want to understand what we are discussing.”

The man with the ring turned to the servant.

“Bring a map of the seven kingdoms. If there is one here.”

“There is, Your Majesty.”

The sheet intended for their joint refusal was pushed to the edge of the table, out of the way of the map.

In the margins: 15 · 16

5. Twenty-Eight

They could not lay the map on the table at once.

The glasses had to be cleared away, the candlesticks moved, and the kings asked to step back. Two servants unrolled the thick sheet while a third held down an edge: the map had been rolled up for a long time and was trying to recover its former shape.

“Put something on it,” said the king with the ring.

The servant looked at a candlestick.

“Not that. The wax will drip.”

They brought two heavy books. One went on the edge of the map, the other opposite. Now the world lay flat.

The kings stood around the table.

Each found his own land first. One was shaded lighter, another darker. Small marks stood for large cities. The rivers looked thin and obedient. Water did not leave the wells; the dry forest did not burn. Three towns stood along the coast, though in one of them only the upper street remained.

The previously silent king covered that town with a finger.

“What year is this map from?”

The servant told him. The king nodded without moving his hand.

The man with the ring asked quietly:

“Has it reached the lower houses?”

“The steps where we used to walk with the children.”

At his son’s wedding, the man with the ring had gone down those steps to the sea. He had thought them far too long. He remembered complaining about them to the bride’s father.

“We could discuss resettlement,” he said.

“We did.”

“You insisted on keeping your courts and your taxes.”

The silent king lifted his finger. The town reappeared, whole, complete with the harbor symbol. The same map hung in his chancellery. He had refused to have it replaced by the one on which the cartographer had drawn the new shoreline.

The gray-haired king pointed to a border.

“There is a mistake here.”

This time the mistake was found at once.

“It is an old map,” said the king by the window.

“The border was there before too.”

“On your map.”

The servants stood nearby, waiting to see whether more books would be needed. The eastern king dismissed them. The door closed.

“If we begin with borders, we shall never get back to the letter today,” he said.

“We have already reached the letter,” the gray-haired king replied. “That is why we are looking at a map.”

The king in the dark coat leaned closer.

“It is strange, all the same, that land does not interest him.”

“He knows how to get it without us,” someone said.

“So they say.”

“Are you suggesting we find out?”

The eastern king laid his palm on the edge of the table.

“We have seven kingdoms. There are no others on this map. Whichever one we have to divide, it will not be small.”

The gray-haired king meant to object to “have to,” but the king with the ring spoke first.

“That is why we must not hurry. More than one evening depends on this.”

He spoke as though warning them against a hasty purchase.

Every kingdom had roads, fields, forests, harbors. In the towns, people lit fires, cooked meals, waited for those who had not yet come home. In some places water had only just begun to arrive after the drought. In others there was still too much of it.

On the map, all this fitted inside a patch of color.

“It is not a sack of coins,” said the gray-haired king. “You cannot tip it out on the table and count out an equal share for everyone.”

The king by the window nodded.

“Exactly. One of us would get a coastline, another empty land. So we must decide in advance what counts as equal.”

“That was not what I meant.”

“But the question does not go away.”

The king with the ring reached for the book holding down the map. An old title was stamped on its spine. He recognized it and pulled the book free, keeping his elbow on the sheet.

The edge of the map rose at once.

“Leave it,” said the eastern king.

“There is something about this in here.”

They opened the book.

The pages turned reluctantly. A ribbon remained between two of them, faded long ago to the color of the paper itself. The king with the ring did not find the passage at once. The gray-haired king waited impatiently, then bent to see what he was looking for.

A crown had been drawn at the top of the page. Beneath it began the history of the seven kingdoms.

“Here,” said the king with the ring. “The land has been divided before. More than once.”

He ran his finger along a line.

It said that after the great war, twenty-eight people had remained on the whole earth, three from each of the seven tribes: the king, his wife, and his chief adviser.

No one was surprised by the sentence.

They had known it since childhood. It appeared at the beginning of textbooks, in ceremonial speeches, and beneath large paintings showing the founding of the world. The paintings contained as many people as the artist thought looked right.

The king by the window examined the line.

“Twenty-eight,” he read.

“Yes.”

“Three each.”

The king with the ring moved his finger, as though it might have been blocking the words.

“From seven tribes.”

For a while they all looked at the page.

“An old edition,” the king in the dark coat said at last.

He said it with sufficient respect to make further inquiry unnecessary.

Other books counted the survivors differently. Some spoke of five people from each tribe, others of ten. An adviser might have had a daughter who had taken no part in the fighting. A queen might have had a woman who helped her dress and prepare food. There were people remembered later only when someone needed to explain who had brought the water or gathered the grain that remained.

There had been no room for them in the principal list.

There had been room for twenty-eight at once.

“It is not about the number,” said the king with the ring.

“The land?” asked the gray-haired king.

“The fact that they managed to agree.”

The gray-haired king drew the book toward him and looked at the beginning of the account.

They had not agreed at once.

The tribes had fought for so long that children learned the names of their enemies before the names of distant places. Every tribe told a different story about the same battle. They spoke at length about their own dead. Of the others, they gave a number.

A warrior was expected not to surrender. If he could no longer

win, he was to kill as many enemies as possible before dying himself.

The enemies observed the same custom.

It was considered a good custom. New songs confirmed this every year.

Then only a hundred people remained in each tribe.

Seven hundred proved enough to continue the war. By then they knew more about one another. They met familiar faces on the battlefield. They remembered the voice of the man who had been shouting from the other side the day before.

That did not make it easier to stop.

Behind each of them stood those already dead. They could not be brought back, but the next death could be explained by the last.

At length there were no warriors left.

There were not even any commanders capable of leading someone into a final battle. The commanders knew how to fight too, and so had died before those to whom battles were recounted.

A morning came when no one was left to obey the order to march.

The kings waited for reports. Their advisers went outside to see whether anyone was coming. They returned empty-handed and tried not yet to say what they already understood.

Beyond their dwellings lay a vast land. It was no longer crowded. A person could walk a long way without meeting either an enemy or one of his own.

The people who remained with the kings began looking for food.

At some point, this became more important than arguing over who owned the place where some could still be found.

Then the men who knew only how to send others met.

They had no one left to fight.

So they talked.

In the book, this conversation took up less space than the list of their titles. It was followed by descriptions of new borders, emblems, customs, and the right to pass power on.

The gray-haired king covered the lower half of the page with his palm.

“They stopped when they ran out of people.”

“They found a way,” replied the king with the ring.

“When they ran out of people.”

“But they found it.”

The gray-haired king turned another page. Beside a date in the chronicle, a different hand had left a slender note. Its ink had browned before that of the main text.

“‘In the hundredth year, again,’” he read.

The eastern king bent over the book.

“It is a marginal note. I have seen another: ‘In a different guise.’”

Old people spoke of such centuries, and children repeated what they said. A hundred years passed, and what had happened seemed to return, only people no longer recognized it. Instead of a war banner above the gates, they

hung an announcement of a fair trial. Instead of swords, they brought papers. Instead of one sovereign demanding obedience, a council gathered, each member swearing that he was protecting the rest.

The gray-haired king remembered his tutor checking it against the dates. Between two disasters there were ninety-eight years; between two others, a hundred and three. One chronicle counted the years from a coronation, another from the end of a war. The tutor had not allowed the numbers to be altered for the sake of a pleasing answer. But neither had he laughed at the note itself.

Now the gray-haired king looked for the next entry. At the bottom of the page, a name had been scraped away. Beneath it remained another, no longer legible. After the account had been copied, someone had decided that the wrong man had been blamed for the old disaster.

“How long has it been now?” his younger brother asked.

“Long enough to read it,” the gray-haired king replied.

“I asked about years.”

“And I do not want to count them.”

He laid his palm on the open book. On the table were fresh ink,

new borders, and seven living people. None of them had been born in the year that page described. None was obliged to repeat what was written there, even if some future scribe found an exact number for the repetition.

The eastern king looked once more at the note, then at the blank sheet for their refusal. The pen lay beside it. He moved it so that it would not roll off the edge, and did nothing else.

The king by the window reached toward the map. The freed corner was curling up again, and he held it down with his glass. A damp ring remained on the paper.

“Do not,” said the eastern king.

The other lifted the glass and began wiping the mark with his sleeve. The border blurred only a little.

“Today, at least, we are sitting at the same table,” the eastern king said.

He took a folded order from his inside pocket. He did not open it, only laid it across the lower half of the open page. His court’s seal showed at the fold.

“My son is waiting to learn which road to take with the troops. He cannot wait forever.”

The king in the dark coat looked at the seal.

“Under the treaty, your troops should have withdrawn from the crossing.”

“They stayed to prevent…”

The eastern king fell silent. He could have finished the familiar phrase about preserving peace. Here it was already too well known.

“They stayed,” he repeated. “If we establish mutual inspections now, we can begin with a withdrawal. On both sides.”

“Yours first.”

The king with the ring moved closer to them.

“And whose council will recognize my son’s rights of succession?”

“That is a separate question.”

“For you.”

The previously silent king asked whether the new treaty would include the settlers’ right to keep their own courts. The gray-haired king’s younger brother wanted to know whose seal the decision would bear: his name must not be written after everyone else’s again. The conversation was difficult, and had already begun. The eastern king opened his order, leaving room for amendments.

The man in the dark coat repeated:

“Your troops first. You can put the date here.”

The eastern king looked at him. He had intended to offer peace to all seven of them, and instead he was being made to answer an accusation from one. There was still plenty of space in the margins of the order.

“We shall not draw up an agreement in an hour,” he said, and folded the sheet.

“We have the evening,” the gray-haired king replied.

“And then? Back to the same disputes, until people die?”

“Then we go on disputing.”

The eastern king put the order away. His son was still at the crossing. He pictured him as the boy he had once been, with someone else’s enormous saber at his belt. Now his son chose his own weapons, commanded men, and waited for his father to send not a story of a great reconciliation, but a few final lines.

“Perhaps we can settle more after the performance,” the eastern king said.

The gray-haired king turned Brown’s letter toward him.

“Where does it say that?”

“Not everything is written down.”

“There is nothing here about peace.”

The eastern king pushed the letter away. At the fold of the order in his pocket, a blank space remained for the date of withdrawal.

The king in the dark coat slowly passed his hand above the line of mountains.

“People have lived here for generations. They will not get up and move wherever we point.”

The gray-haired king turned toward him.

“At least that is understood, then.”

“It means the border must be drawn so that no one has to move.”

He lowered his finger toward the valley.

“Along the river?”

“The river runs through several places,” said the king with the ring. “Whoever gets the headwaters will be able to quarrel with all the others.”

“Along the road, then.”

“The road will have to be divided.”

“It crosses borders already.”

The eastern king closed the book.

For a moment, the sound of the pages striking together could be heard.

They all looked at him, but he merely set the heavy volume back on the edge of the map. The paper flattened.

The gray-haired king stepped away from the table.

He could still say the discussion was over and leave. But now they were touching the part of the map beside his own border. If they began drawing lines without him, afterward he would have to argue with a line already drawn.

“That land is not empty,” he said.

“We can see that,” they replied.

He bent and pointed to the place where the road turned toward the river.

“Do not cut here. The whole road is needed.”

The king with the ring stopped beside him.

“For those who lost their homes in the fires?”

The gray-haired king did not answer at once. This was his brother’s land. His brother had already offered to let the people through without any division; the gray-haired king had not yet accepted.

“There are houses there,” he said.

“Then we shall settle them there.”

The gray-haired king straightened, as though only now hearing his own words.

No one had a pencil yet.

The king with the ring asked for one to be brought.

“Not on this map,” the eastern king quickly added. “Find a copy.”

They moved the candlesticks closer. The small marks for towns and roads became easier to examine.

The book about the twenty-eight survivors lay closed.

6. A Valley for Three

The copy of the map arrived with the pencil.

It had fewer decorations than the first. The animals and ships drawn around the edges were missing, but the roads were easier to see.

The kings watched the servant spread out the paper.

No one picked up the pencil.

After the long discussion, they all needed to leave the room. One wanted to wash; another wanted to see the room prepared for him. The ship was visible from the terrace, with clean washing being

hung on its deck. The eastern king proposed a short break. Important matters were difficult to consider on an empty stomach, he said.

The gray-haired king looked at him but said nothing.

They did not leave together.

The king by the window lingered near the door, waiting for the one with the broad ring. They walked a few steps in silence. When a servant offered to show them to a sitting room, the king by the window said he remembered the way.

They turned in another direction.

“You understand I don’t want this?” he asked.

The king with the ring nodded.

“Of course.”

“But if we can’t agree to refuse, we must at least avoid being the ones left exposed.”

“I understand.”

There was a bench against the wall. The king by the window sat down and indicated the place beside him. His companion preferred to remain standing.

“I don’t intend to support any choice against you,” the seated king said.

“I, too, am counting on us not to let one another down.”

The king by the window glanced along the corridor. There was no one there.

He took out the letter to the doctors. A small writing table stood beside the bench; it held sand, ink, and a pen. He laid the sheet before him.

“Can you witness my signature?”

The man with the ring came closer.

At the bottom, consent was required for independent doctors to visit, and for the girl to be excused from court appearances

while she was under their care. The king reread the second line.

“‘While she is under their care.’ No date.”

“Put in a date,” said the man with the ring.

“And if they say they need longer?”

The pen remained in its groove. The king ran his finger over the blank space beneath the letter, as though his signature were already there and he could rub it out.

“Leave it. You don’t know what this is about.”

His companion stepped back from the table. He did not, in fact,

know the full extent of the illness; he knew only that he could now ask far more of the man sitting before him than he could have before.

The king by the window put the letter away.

“If it does come to land, I need the valley.”

The king with the ring did not ask which one.

There was one valley on the map to which they had returned more often than to the others. A road ran through it, a river followed the road, and between the river and the slopes lay enough fields to make them a pleasure to look at. Everyone knew its uses. It still

belonged to one of the seven, but they tried not to remind one another of that aloud.

“It’s quiet there,” the seated king said. “There would be no need to take her through three courts where everyone has the right to ask questions.”

“Take whom?”

“It doesn’t matter. If he agrees to hear me, I’ll need somewhere. A house of my own, not rooms with her grandfather.”

The king with the ring nodded. He could have pointed out that the grandfather had offered doctors, not a claim of ownership over the child. Instead, he said:

“That can be arranged.”

“I don’t need half the road and another bank from which someone can count my carts. The whole valley.”

The king with the ring turned it a little on his finger.

“Of course. Otherwise, why begin this conversation?”

“You promise?”

“If it is among the lands we divide, I’ll support you.”

The seated man was not satisfied.

“Support means saying something pleasant. I need the valley.”

The king with the ring leaned closer.

“It will be yours.”

The king by the window looked at his empty hands. He had not signed permission to invite the doctors; the agreement over someone else’s valley, however, was almost ready.

“And if the question of your heir arises,” he said, “my court will not stand aside.”

“That is good to hear.”

After that, it became easier to talk about anything else.

They discussed where water could be prepared for washing, whether it was time to light more

candles, and why the rooms in this palace were so inconveniently arranged. Then the king by the window stood up.

“You may count on me,” he said.

The king with the ring waited until he had gone, then passed a hand over his forehead.

He had not acquired the valley. But the promise had already worked: one man now intended to protect his life.

He set off toward the room where food was being served.

He did not reach it.

The king in the dark coat stood at an open window, holding a glass. When he saw his neighbor, he

stepped aside as though making room for him in the fresh air.

“I’m glad you came out,” he said. “I wanted to talk.”

The king with the ring stopped.

“About what?”

“What we can’t discuss in front of everyone.”

Cool air drifted through the open window. The king in the dark coat put his glass on the sill.

“I don’t want to find myself hemmed in by other people’s borders. You saw the map.”

“I did.”

“If the road goes to one man, the river to another, and the fields to

a third, we'll have to start all over again. Everyone will be waiting for his neighbor to do something unpleasant."

"That's why we must discuss it beforehand."

"You can pass through it without going through the outposts," the king in the dark coat continued. "If the road were mine, they would have no need to hide him in the mountains."

"Your son wrote that he would come of his own accord."

"Has everyone been reading my correspondence today?"

"Your cousin mentioned it in front of us."

The king in the dark coat picked up his glass but did not drink.

“He wants guarantees for those people. First a dozen, then a hundred. Then they’ll say they intend to stay with him when he comes home.”

“You could begin by talking.”

“I talked to him for twenty years.”

He turned away. Outside, two gardeners were folding a ladder, holding it at either end.

“I need the whole valley.”

The king with the ring looked at the glass.

There was a little water left at the bottom.

“You understand,” his companion continued, “I’m not asking for it for nothing.”

“And what do you offer?”

The king in the dark coat looked him straight in the face.

“To stand beside you when the choosing begins. Sometimes that is worth more than land.”

“It matters to me that no one at home should question my son’s claim.”

“That I understand,” said the king in the dark coat. “I can promise you the same.”

They were talking about their sons now, and it made the bargain seem to both of them

almost an act of care for their families.

For a brief moment, there seemed to be less air in the corridor.

The king with the ring nodded.

“We can come to an agreement.”

“Then let’s do it now. You’ll have other things to think about later.”

He spoke without smiling. A smile would have allowed them to pretend that none of this had been entirely serious.

“The valley will be in your hands,” said the king with the ring.

His companion finally drank the water.

“I’ll remember.”

They stood by the window a little longer. In the courtyard, the gardeners were carrying away the folded ladder. One held the upper end, the other guided the lower. Both knew what would happen if either let go too soon.

The king in the dark coat left first.

The one who remained watched him go. Then he adjusted his ring and finally went to eat.

He sat at a small table, apart from the others. The food arrived quickly. A servant asked if everything was to his liking.

The king said it was, though he had not tasted it.

He was thinking about the valley.

He could explain to one man that he had meant the road. To the other, that he had been referring to the river. He could offer different land, add money, remind them of the difficult hour in which they had made their agreements.

First, he had to live long enough to explain.

He picked up his spoon.

Another king stopped beside him—the one who had said almost nothing during their discussion. He waited until his neighbor noticed him, then asked if the place was free.

“Of course.”

He sat down.

The servant brought a second place setting.

They ate in silence for a while. The king with the ring was grateful for it. Here, at least, he thought he would not have to promise anything.

“You’ve spoken to the others,” his neighbor said at last.

It was not a question.

The king with the ring put down his spoon.

“Everyone is talking.”

“Not to me.”

“We’re talking now.”

His neighbor looked at him calmly.

“Then tell me: why should I support you in particular?”

“Our children are married. Are you asking why you should spare the father of your daughter’s husband?”

His neighbor lowered his spoon.

“And you only ask that now.”

“I offered places for your people.”

“Under your officials.”

“Under the people who live and work there. They can’t disappear because your sea has risen.”

His neighbor looked at his plate. A blue pattern ran around its edge, like a coastline. At home, he had received an estimate for moving a school; the teacher had asked to begin before winter. Another building could be found across the border. He would have to agree to the children studying there alongside other children, under someone else's timetable.

"I brought you a letter from my daughter," he said.

The man with the ring looked up.

"Why didn't you give it to me before?"

"It's for both of us."

He took out the sheet but did not lay it on the table. His daughter was asking her husband's father to make room for families from the coastal villages. She was asking her own father to stop arguing over who would collect their taxes. The last line was about a child who wanted to know when they would both visit.

The other father held out his hand. The king put the letter away.

"Later. Tell me now what we can agree on."

The king with the ring pushed his plate away. He no longer wanted to eat.

"What do you want?"

“The valley. All of it. So that my people don’t become yours in a single winter.”

“People need roofs.”

“And a king.”

He had said it too quickly. Now he had to look his companion in the face until the other man looked away first.

The king with the ring lowered his eyes to his hand. A crumb had lodged against the gold band. He picked it off with a fingernail and laid it on the edge of his plate.

“It’s an important place.”

“That’s why I named it.”

“Others may ask for it too.”

“Then you’ll have to decide whom to count on.”

The silence between them lengthened.

The king with the ring glanced toward the door. Anyone might come in. In particular, someone to whom the valley already belonged by promise.

“Very well,” he said. “The valley is yours.”

His neighbor finished eating, laid down his spoon neatly, and stood up.

“Now I have a better idea what we’re talking about.”

He left without unnecessary thanks.

The remaining king drew his plate toward him again but did not eat.

The valley had been promised to three men. Not three parts of it: all of it to each. The man with the ring imagined them meeting beside the same bridge, each holding his word. But that would happen later, when his own name was no longer in danger of being struck from the list of the living.

For now, he sat up straighter. Three men had agreed to protect him, and for a moment he felt once more like a father who had managed to protect his son.

When the kings returned to the hall, the copy of the map lay where they had left it. So did the pencil.

The gray-haired king's younger brother came in behind the man with the ring. At the threshold, he caught his sleeve.

"You said you would support recognition of my reign."

"If we stay together."

"On the paper card too?"

The man with the ring looked into the room.

"Let's not stand here where everyone can see us. You can count on me."

The younger brother released his sleeve. He wanted to ask what “together” meant, but the others were already waiting at the table. He sat down, adjusted his glass, and nodded to another neighbor with whom he had managed to speak in the corridor. The man answered with an almost imperceptible movement of his head.

The eastern king asked whether everyone had had enough time to think.

No one wished to answer at length.

The gray-haired king sat down last. This time he rested his hands on the arms of his chair at once,

without moving closer to the map.

“I still think we can refuse,” he said.

The king by the window answered:

“You’ve said that already.”

“Repeating it hasn’t made it any less true.”

“No. But we aren’t getting anywhere.”

“Sometimes it’s better to get nowhere than to go where you’re being called.”

The eastern king looked at Brown’s letter.

“Nothing prevents us from writing a different answer.”

He turned the blank sheet so that it was easy to reach from any side.

The gray-haired king looked at it. Then at the men with whom he was being invited to sign it.

“Which of you promises not to go to him alone after we have refused together?”

This time, silence came more quickly. There was no need to rehearse possible apologies, chance visits, and extraordinary hospitality aloud. Each heard the old question and remembered why he had not wished to answer it the first time.

The king with the ring began to speak about choosing.

Not whom to choose. He said nothing about that yet.

“If we start arguing aloud, everyone will keep trying to persuade the others to the very end. We could sit here for another day.”

“And?” the gray-haired king asked.

“It can be settled more quietly.”

Small sheets of paper were brought.

The servant laid them beside the glasses, not knowing what they were for. Noticing that one was a little larger than the rest, he

replaced it. Then he set ink on the table and stepped back.

“In secret, as he proposed,” said the king with the ring. “So no one can put pressure on anyone else.”

He did not look at any of the men to whom he had promised the valley.

“What do we write?” asked the king in the dark coat.

The question was quiet.

For a while, no one answered.

The eastern king ran a finger along the edge of his sheet.

“He proposes that we mark those we wish to keep alive.”

The gray-haired king looked up.

“And what does that change?”

“We will be choosing whom to save.”

“And the one with the fewest votes?”

The eastern king took his hand off the paper.

“Loses.”

The word had neither a face nor a voice. It asked no one to stop.

The king by the window pulled the ink toward him.

“That’s clearer,” he said.

The gray-haired king looked at him, then at the king with the ring. The latter sat upright, his hands still, as though everything

he had arranged during the short break depended on the exactness of his posture.

The blank sheet for their joint refusal lay in the middle of the table.

It could still be picked up.

But the little cards were closer.

In the margins: 17 · 18

7. Fewest of All

They did not begin writing at once.

The cards lay before them. The pens were ready. Each had names of people he intended to keep alive, and there was still time to change that list.

The king with the broad ring was the first to draw an inkwell toward him.

The gray-haired king looked at his blank card.

“We do understand what we’re doing?” he asked.

No one said that he did not.

That was easier than saying that he did.

The gray-haired king's younger brother looked at the blank sheet in the middle of the table. Very little needed to be written there: "We refuse. We leave tomorrow." In his own name, less still.

He drew his card closer. At home, they were waiting not for his return but for news of who had received the new king. If he returned from the island with nothing, the talk would begin again: a council, a review of appointments, the right of the old families to halt his decrees. In his mind he made a war out of these words; from the war he turned to those who had already suffered

for him, and decided not to waste any more time.

The pen scratched across the paper.

The gray-haired king looked up. His brother was writing quickly. He did not look at any of those whose names he did not intend to include. When he finished, he folded the card and smoothed the crease with a fingernail.

First.

For a moment, he felt better. Now the others were catching up with him, not he with them. He rested his palm on the folded paper, to keep himself from opening it and reading it again.

The king by the window took out the letter to the doctors. He put it beneath his card so the pen would not catch on the roughness of the table. The words “consent to a visit” showed beneath the lower edge.

He turned the letter over. Now the blank reverse showed.

The eastern king watched his hands.

“Don’t do this in her name,” he said quietly.

“I’m not writing her name.”

That was true. The little card bore the names of grown men the girl knew from celebrations. The king finished the last, covered the

writing with his hand, and realized he was breathing through his mouth.

The eastern king picked up his own pen. He wanted to take out his orders to his son again and write in a date for the withdrawal. He could already see how the discussion would begin: his neighbor would demand that he remove his troops first, the others would add conditions, and he would have to admit that the peace in which he had taken pride for so many years had depended, in part, on concessions put off until later. They were waiting for his card.

He wrote one name. Stopped.

“What if he refuses afterward?” he asked.

The king with the ring looked up.

“To perform?”

The eastern king nodded, though he was not thinking of the performance.

“The letter says he might.”

“You pointed that out yourself.”

“I remember.”

The man with the ring made no promises on Brown’s behalf. The eastern king sat before his unfinished list, and none of the others’ silences helped him turn hope into an agreement. Then he finished writing.

The king in the dark coat twice brought his pen to the same place and twice drew it back. Among his papers lay his son's letter. His son had asked to be heard without guards present. Here, the father was agreeing to listen to a man who demanded murder, though he had not promised to bring anyone back.

He dipped the pen sharply. A blot appeared on the card.

"Another," he said.

The servant handed him a fresh sheet. The king folded the spoiled one and put it away: he could not leave it on the table in case it was counted as a vote. He filled in the clean card without stopping.

The gray-haired king's pen was dry.

He looked at his brother. The younger man nudged his card toward the middle of the table and said:

"We've all decided."

"Not yet."

"Then decide."

The gray-haired king could have stood up a second time. His luggage had already been sent to the ship; he would not even have to pack. Instead, he smoothed the report in his pocket without taking it out. The name of the burning village lay directly beneath his thumb.

On the map, houses were marked beyond someone else's border. If they became his houses, no one would ask by what right he had brought people there. He would not have to wait for another man's permission, yield to an officer at an outpost, hear the displaced people thanking a different king.

The gray-haired king dipped his pen.

The previously silent king finished before him. For a long time, he looked at the father of his daughter's husband, who had promised him the valley. Then he moved the card off his sleeve, beneath which lay his daughter's letter, and folded it. The letter

had still not been read by both men.

When the last card was folded, they all stopped pretending at once that they were not interested in what the others had written.

Someone suggested having the servant collect them.

The eastern king shook his head.

“We’ll do it ourselves.”

The servant stepped back.

The gray-haired king reached for the nearest card, changed his mind, and pushed a small dish into the middle. One after another, all seven cards were placed on it. They were shuffled.

Now it was almost impossible to remember whose was on top, although each man had watched his own until the last moment.

The king by the window was asked to unfold them.

He picked up the first card and held it closed for a while.

“Just read it,” said the man with the ring.

The king by the window unfolded the paper.

He began to read the names.

It was easy to listen while one’s own name was being spoken. Afterward, each man listened to the pause before the next.

Someone counted on his fingers beneath the table.

The second card was opened more quickly.

At the third, the king who had finished writing first looked up.

His name had not come where he expected. Or, more precisely, it had not come where it ought to have come.

He looked at the man with the ring.

The man was watching the cards.

The fourth was read and placed beside the others.

The servant in the corner lowered his eyes, though no one had asked what he could hear.

The fifth card had to be flattened: an edge had bent over and covered part of a line. The reader paused for a moment. Someone at the table drew a sharp breath, then adjusted his collar as though that were the trouble.

The sixth.

The seventh.

All that remained was to count the marks made beside the names on a separate sheet.

It did not take long.

The king by the window ran a finger down the lines. Stopped.

Counted the relevant one again, though he had not recounted any of the others.

“Who?” asked the man in the dark coat.

The reader looked up.

The king who had folded his card first understood before he heard the answer.

“Give it here,” he said.

They passed him the sheet.

He pulled the light closer and began counting for himself. Everyone else waited with a patience they had not shown when he spoke before the vote.

Then he took the cards.

He laid them out beside one another. On some, the handwriting was easy to recognize. He did not name the writers aloud, only let his eyes linger a little longer on certain lines.

The result did not change.

“But we had an agreement,” he said to the man with the ring.

The man slowly took his hand off the table.

“We agreed to vote.”

“Before that.”

The room grew smaller, though no one had moved.

The king with the cards looked at another neighbor.

“You promised too.”

The man adjusted his cup on its saucer.

“Circumstances changed.”

“When?”

There was no answer.

The gray-haired king drew back from the table but did not rise. His face looked as though he were finally about to say what he had proposed before.

The chosen man looked at him.

The gray-haired king looked at his brother’s card. One of the names he had hoped to see was

missing. He wanted to take offense—so badly, as though that offense could help him now. He looked away.

“The cards can be put away,” said the eastern king.

No one moved.

“No,” said the man before whom they lay. “Leave them for now.”

He was still looking for an error in the papers that could be corrected. A misread letter. A misplaced mark. Something that would allow the others to smile and admit there had been a misunderstanding.

Then he stopped looking.

“I can pay,” he said.

The man in the dark coat looked up.

“For what?”

“For the performance. For everything. Whatever he wants.”

“He doesn’t need money.”

“I mean you.”

No one asked him to explain.

The king braced his palms on the table and straightened.

“We can write a different answer. Say no one agreed.”

He saw his own card among the others and stopped.

“No. Say we agreed and changed our minds. Nothing has happened yet.”

The last sentence was true.

That made it especially unpleasant for those who had already begun to feel relief.

The king with the ring tapped a fingernail on the edge of the table.

“And who will look like a man who doesn’t keep his word?”

The chosen man looked at him.

“You’re worried about that now?”

The servant in the corner stirred. The eastern king told him to leave.

The door closed.

The chosen king stood up.

The king in the dark coat rose too. He stood between him and the door. The handle was unobstructed; beyond it there was neither a bolt nor a guard posted by the host. He laid his palm on it.

“Move,” said the chosen man.

He did not step aside.

“I signed the invitation myself,” the chosen man said. “Not this.”

The man at the door looked at the cards on the table.

“You voted too.”

That was true as well.

It did not make what was happening necessary, but the man who said it wanted it to.

“I know,” said the chosen man. “I meant to be sitting where you are. I know.”

He was not asking to be judged better than the others. He looked at the hand holding the door and waited for it to fall away after all.

It did not.

The chosen man slowly returned to his place. He did not sit down. He stood with his hands on the chair back, looking at the people with whom, a moment earlier, he had intended to divide another man’s kingdom.

Now they intended to divide his.

The valley remained at the edge of the map. Someone had already drawn a thin pencil line beside it.

He noticed it for the first time.

“You didn’t even wait,” he said.

The king with the ring stopped tapping his nail.

The gray-haired king opened his mouth, then closed it. The eastern king laid his hands on the table. The man in the dark coat turned away from the map.

The man with the ring called the servant. The king in the dark coat opened the door just far enough for an order to be given.

“Six daggers,” said the man with the ring.

The gray-haired king gripped the arms of his chair. Until that moment, no weapons had been ordered. Now an order had been spoken, and someone outside the door had begun to carry it out.

“Wait,” said the younger brother.

The servant did stop.

The king with the ring repeated:

“Six.”

The footsteps receded.

After a while, a voice outside asked permission to enter.

No one answered at once.

It was not a new letter that came in.

Six daggers lay on a tray.

In the margins: 19 · 20

8. Six Hands

The tray was held by the man who had been told to bring the weapons.

In the corridor, he had asked once more how many daggers were needed. They repeated the number but did not explain why one would not do. He chose six that looked alike, checked that their handles were not loose, and laid them in a row.

Now no one would take one.

The servant stood beside the table. The tray was heavy. Holding it at arm’s length was becoming difficult, but he did not

dare set it down without permission.

“Here,” the king with the ring said at last.

There was not enough room on the table. The map, cards, and open inkwells lay there. To make room for the tray, they had to move the blank sheet intended for their refusal.

The eastern king folded it in half and pushed it aside.

“You may go.”

The servant left. The door did not close at once: the handle stuck, and he carefully pulled it again. Everyone waited for this minor inconvenience to be resolved.

Then the king who was to die said:

“You don’t know how.”

He looked at the daggers.

“It isn’t the same as on paper.”

The king in the dark coat moved the tray away from an inkwell.

“Don’t.”

“Don’t what? Speak?”

The man did not answer.

The chosen king went to the window. No one stopped him. They all knew there was no way out through it: outside were a drop, stone, and too little room even to place a foot.

People were walking below.

One carried a basket; another stopped to let him pass. A gardener gathered tools that had been left beside the wall. He bent to look for something and did not straighten for a long time.

The king watched him search.

Then he turned.

“If I call out now, what will you say?”

“Don’t call,” said the gray-haired king.

“Why?”

The gray-haired king could find no answer he wished to speak.

“You said we could refuse.”

“I still think so.”

“Then refuse.”

The gray-haired king rested his palms on the table. A card lay between them. He pushed it aside.

“We should have done it together.”

“There are still seven of us.”

No one contradicted him.

The younger brother left the window and went toward the gray-haired king. The man in the dark coat took a step after him, but the gray-haired king raised a hand. He stopped.

“You said you’d come with me,” his brother said. “Come. We’ll hear them out. I’ll accept a council.”

The gray-haired king looked at him.

“Now?”

“Now. Not before. I know.”

“I offered before.”

The younger man nodded. As he waited, he kept opening and closing his fingers, but no longer tried to hide their trembling.

“You haven’t stopped being my brother because I wouldn’t listen.”

The gray-haired king reached toward him. His hand traveled halfway, then dropped onto the back of the chair.

“Your people can pass through,” the younger man added. “All of them. Across my land. I’ll sign now.”

The gray-haired king flinched. He had not yet managed to accept the offer, even here.

“You would have bargained,” he said.

“I offered without bargaining. And I’ll sign now.”

It was not a noble promise made by a man with nothing to fear. The younger man was afraid. He

offered land, agreed to a council, and to anything else there was still time to name. But the road to the houses near the border had existed before, and no line on the map required its owner to die for it.

The king with the ring said quietly:

“He’ll make promises to everyone like that.”

The silent king looked at him. For a moment, both remembered the valley, but only one knew how many men had already been promised it.

For a while, the chosen man stopped looking at the weapons. He looked only at faces. Each held

something familiar: a habit of narrowing the eyes when an answer was difficult, a crease beside the mouth, fingers moving over the table. In the past, such signs had told him when he could raise a price and when it was better to end a conversation.

Now he needed to read something else.

“I won’t tell anyone,” he said. “Not about the letter or the cards. We’ll all leave. None of it happened.”

The king with the ring was looking at his own hand.

“It already happened.”

“What? We sat at a table. We talked. Everything else can still be left undone.”

Something fell on the other side of the wall. The sound was loud and entirely out of place. Someone in the next room apologized.

The king by the window stepped toward the tray.

Not the one they had chosen: the one who had sat by the window earlier and read the names. He picked up a dagger as though to show the others that a weapon by itself decided nothing.

Then he looked at his neighbors’ empty hands.

“Everyone,” he said.

The king with the ring raised his head.

“That’s what the letter says.”

“I don’t mean the letter.”

He held the dagger point down. The letter to the doctors had been put away; nothing showed beneath his cuff now. The eastern king looked at the hand of his daughter’s husband, then took the second dagger. He should have restrained that hand. Instead, he made his own like it.

Now the others understood. No one wanted to be left as the man who had done it alone while the others merely watched. No one

wanted a neighbor to retain the right to say: I took no part.

The third dagger was taken more quickly. The man with the ring adjusted his grip to keep the ring clear of the hilt: metal slipped against metal. The previously silent man chose the nearest dagger without testing whether it sat well in his hand. The man in the dark coat glanced at the door one last time and left it for the tray.

The way was clear, but now he stood closer to the chosen man than before.

The gray-haired king was still gripping the edge of the table.

The king with the ring held out a hilt to him. He did not take it. The weapon was laid before him.

“You don’t have to do this,” said the chosen man.

He was no longer addressing them all.

The gray-haired king looked up. Then he looked at the five hands holding daggers.

“Don’t make me,” he said.

It was not clear to whom.

The hilt lay on the table a few moments longer.

The younger brother raised his palm. He pressed his thumb into its middle, his other fingers not

quite straight. The gray-haired king recognized the gesture before he heard the word. As a child, his brother had begged that way not to be reported for breaking a cup; as a grown man, he used it to let someone finish speaking when he already disagreed. The same palm. There was a small old mark on it that the gray-haired king remembered from the days when their hands had been the same size.

“Brother,” the younger man said.

The gray-haired king tried to remember the number of houses across the river. It would not come. Instead, he remembered the two of them carrying a wet blanket: it was heavy for the

younger boy, but he would not let go of his end.

The hilt was very close.

“Don’t,” his brother said.

The gray-haired king took the last dagger. Not because he had ceased to recognize him. He recognized him and kept looking at him until he could force himself to look lower.

The seventh king stepped back. He called to his brother once more, then to another man by name. He was no longer speaking of rights or votes.

The six approached him.

When it was over, the king with the ring was the first to step back.

He looked at his fingers and did not immediately realize that he was still gripping the hilt.

The king by the window ordered a stretcher.

The gray-haired king tried to sit down. His chair was farther away than he thought, and he had to take a step backward, searching for it with his foot. At last he sat. No one helped him.

People came in. They did not ask what had happened. They lifted the body, straightened the cloth, and looked at the doorway: could they pass through without striking the jamb?

They could.

Outside, one of the bearers asked the other to walk more slowly.

The six remained in the hall.

The eastern king collected the cards. He stacked them without reading them again, but made the edges even.

“We must tell Brown,” said the king in the dark coat.

The man with the ring looked at him.

“That everything is ready?”

“That we’ve agreed.”

“He’ll understand.”

The gray-haired king closed his eyes.

Soon water was brought for their hands. The servant placed the basin where the tray had been. The kings approached one at a time. The water quickly ceased to be clear. It was changed, then changed again.

Clean cloths were handed to them.

The gray-haired king held his wet hands above the basin. The edge of the report in his pocket grew damp when he reached for his handkerchief. He took it out and saw the familiar request to move the people out. Nothing new had appeared in the report. He laid the paper on the table and dried his hands.

The king by the window still had his unsigned permission for the doctors. The eastern king had not sent orders for the troops to withdraw. The man in the dark coat had not answered his son. All these things could still be done, but none of them could now make what had happened cease to have happened.

Lines remained on the map. Some were barely sketched; others had already been traced more firmly. The pencil lay beside the valley.

The king with the ring picked it up.

He did not look at the men to whom he had made the same promise. The final division could

wait. For now, he had to draw six portions so that no one would begin arguing before dinner.

“Here,” said one of his neighbors.

The king with the ring moved the pencil.

“Like this?”

“For now.”

The gray-haired king opened his eyes.

A fresh sheet was laid on the table. An answer had to be written.

The words saying the conditions had been fulfilled had to be corrected.

Not all of them. Not yet.

9. The Place Settings

They ordered the chair removed after the table had been laid.

At first the young servant thought another chair would replace it. This happened. A guest noticed a crack in the carving, disliked the height of the back, or remembered sitting in a different chair at a particularly successful dinner.

The servant lifted the chair, carried it to the wall, and stopped.

“Which one shall I bring?”

The senior servant looked at him.

“None.”

The place setting remained on the table before the empty space.

“This too?”

“All of it.”

He gathered the plate, glasses, knife, and fork. He took the napkin last. It was so neatly folded that he did not want to unfold it.

Instead he laid it on the plate and carried everything to the clean dishes.

Six royal places remained along the table. Brown’s special chair stood apart, positioned so that he could easily see the others.

The young servant returned to the candlesticks.

They were not there merely for decoration. Lighting was a serious responsibility in this house. Flames must burn steadily. Wax must not fall on the cloth. The master's face must never be left in shadow.

Especially a servant's shadow.

When the young man first entered service, this had been explained to him before anyone showed him where the spare candles were kept. He remembered the instructions but did not at first understand why the others spoke the word "shadow" as quietly as the name of a dangerous illness.

Later he stopped asking.

He learned to approach from the side. To serve without letting his head block the light. To bend low enough, yet not so low that another candlestick stretched his shape across the table.

By daylight, it looked like an almost ridiculous exercise.

In the evening, a great deal depended on it.

Now he checked the distances: the chair, the candle, the edge of the dish that would be carried past. If he held the tray a little higher, the shadow would cross the cloth without touching the face.

He tried it with an empty tray.

The senior servant stopped beside him.

“Not so high. You’re not serving over his head.”

The young man lowered his arms.

His shadow fell across the chair back.

Both men looked at it.

“Come in from the side,” said the older man.

The servant went around the chair and tried again.

Footsteps sounded in the corridor. Several people carried something heavy past the room. They did not stop at the door, but

the young servant caught sight of the edge of a stretcher.

He lowered the tray.

The older man said nothing.

Two more people were called to the kitchen. The voices were ordinary. They named dishes, asked for a table to be cleared, checked whether the tools were sharp. It was the ordinariness of the voices that was most frightening.

The young servant looked at the discarded chair.

It stood against the wall, gold paint glinting on its carved back. Nothing about it had changed

since a few minutes earlier, when it was intended for a living man.

The senior servant took the empty tray from his hands, then gave it back.

“Hold it level.”

“Could I work somewhere other than the table tonight?”

The words came out more quietly than he intended.

“Where?”

“In the corridor. By the door.”

The older man looked in the direction the stretcher had gone.

“Everyone would like to be by the door.”

He walked away.

The young servant stayed where he was.

Laughter came from the next room, brief and uncertain. One king said something to another. Then it was quiet again.

The cook stepped into the corridor and told everyone not to crowd around the kitchen. He took off his apron, folded it, immediately unfolded it, and put it on again. His hands could find no work while he spoke. Perhaps that was why he spent so long explaining who should stand where.

The young servant listened and tried to remember only the tasks.

Bring clean bowls.

Check the water.

Remove the extra place setting.

He had already removed it.

When they handed him the special cup, he understood exactly what he would have to carry to the table, although he had understood enough before.

The cup was not silver.

He held it through a folded cloth and did not look inside. For a few moments he stood there, waiting for the next instruction.

Then he drew the free end of the napkin over the top.

The cook looked at him.

“It will be served uncovered.”

“I know.”

For now, he left the napkin where it was.

He had to take the cup across the corridor, place it on the serving table, and return for the ordinary glasses. A few steps. No more than he took dozens of times in an evening.

Today he had to take each one separately.

He set down the cup.

The cloth stayed over it.

The senior servant came later and silently removed the cloth.

He folded it beside the cup. He made no comment.

The young servant watched his hands.

So that was possible too: to say nothing and still do what was expected of you.

Toward evening, Antonio Gonzalez arrived.

He checked the space for the little stage, asked for the nearby table to be cleared, and made sure the puppet box was not in anyone’s way. Two men raised the fabric. Antonio asked them not to pull it too sharply; the fastening might give.

Here, things happened in understandable ways. Pull fabric and it might tear. Leave something in a passage and it might be knocked over. With unexpected relief, the young servant helped move a small table farther from the door.

Antonio thanked him.

Then he noticed the way the servant was holding his hands.

“Did you burn yourself?”

The young man shook his head.

Antonio followed his gaze to the serving table. He walked over, looked, and stopped.

The servant waited.

Perhaps this man would say there had been a misunderstanding. Show them where to take it all. Ask for different dishes.

Antonio said none of those things.

He straightened a fold in the tablecloth beside the tray and slowly stepped back.

“Will they be starting soon?” he asked.

The young servant nodded.

“Then check the candles.”

The servant did not move.

Antonio had already turned toward the screen. One side hung lower than the other, and his eye found the fastening that needed

tightening. He raised a hand to show what must be done, then noticed that the young man was still beside him.

“Did you hear me?”

“Yes.”

“Then—”

“Will I have to bring the cup, too?”

Antonio lowered his hand.

The servant was looking not at him but at a small fold near the shoulder of his coat. It was easier to ask that way. He had noticed before that if you looked a gentleman straight in the face, he might hear something improper in the most ordinary words.

“Were you told to serve it?”

“Yes.”

“Then you will.”

The servant nodded.

The answer was so familiar that he could have left at once. Still he lingered.

“I’m afraid I’ll drop it.”

Antonio looked at his hands. His fingers were clenched as tightly as if he were already holding something heavy.

“Hold the tray with both hands.”

“I’ve tried.”

“It isn’t that heavy.”

The servant looked up.

Antonio said no more.

Nearby, behind the thin fabric, stood the puppet box. Several times today he had checked whether Brown would be able to reach the control bar comfortably. He had checked the table's height, the lighting, the position of the chairs. Everything must arrive as if by itself, before his employer had to ask.

The young man before him had also been put in his place. The right height, quiet in his movements, able to hold a tray. Nothing needed adjusting.

"I can carry other things," the servant said. "Water. Plates. Whatever you like."

He spoke quickly, before his question could be made into a refusal to work.

“I’ll bring anything. Just not—”

He ran out of words. Antonio found himself waiting for the last one, although he understood without it.

He glanced back at the serving table.

The cup stood there, uncovered. There had been no mistake. Nobody meant to take it away, replace it, or decide it was no longer needed. Soon it would be set before men who knew what it was made of, one more thing delivered on time.

“Fetch the senior servant,” Antonio said.

The young man immediately stepped back.

“I’m not refusing.”

“I heard you.”

“Please don’t call him. I’ll serve it.”

Antonio watched him reach for the tray. His palm slid beneath the edge, his fingers found the familiar hollow. He did know how to do this. From a distance, the trembling barely showed.

“Put it down.”

The servant withdrew his hand.

Antonio went to the table himself. He picked up the tray, testing its weight. Holding it was indeed easy. The difficulty was elsewhere, and no well-placed hollow under his fingers helped.

He set the tray down again.

“I’ll serve it to the guests.”

The servant did not understand at once.

“Instead of me?”

“Yes.”

He still waited for more. An explanation of how this would suit Brown. A task that would prove harder than the first. Antonio added nothing.

The senior servant came without being called. He looked at both men, then at the cup.

“What’s the delay?”

“There is none,” Antonio replied. “He’ll tend the candles. I’ll serve this.”

“We have an order of service.”

“The order won’t change.”

“Who will answer for it if anyone asks?”

Antonio wanted to say Mr. Brown. The name was ready. It usually made things easier: doors opened, unnecessary questions fell away, everyone tried to discover what more they could do to help.

But Brown had asked for nothing of the kind.

“I will,” Antonio said.

The older man considered this stout, slightly bewildered figure. Perhaps he thought a famous man’s assistant knew more about the evening than the rest of them. He did not object. He merely reminded Antonio which side of the table to approach from.

Antonio listened.

When the older man had gone, the young servant said quietly, “Thank you.”

Antonio did not know what to do with the thanks. The cup still stood between them. Their

conversation had not canceled the dinner. He had merely agreed to carry something that would be carried anyway if he changed his mind.

“Check the candles,” he repeated, no longer looking away.

The servant nodded. Now he could unclench his fingers.

Antonio took a clean cloth from the table. He folded it several times and placed it beside the tray. Later he could use it to take hold of the tray.

The fabric at the stage still hung unevenly.

He did not straighten it at once.

The servant returned to the hall.

One candle was already leaning; the softened wax no longer held it straight. He steadied the candlestick, straightened the candle, and removed a drop from the cloth before it could harden.

The six places were ready.

So was Brown's.

The chair against the wall was not in anyone's way. Even so, the young servant carried it farther, out through the door. He did not want to see its empty back every time he returned from the kitchen.

When Brown's arrival was announced, he was already standing where he belonged.

He held a clean tray.

His face was required to be calm.

In the margins: 21 · 22

10. Dinner

Brown paused in the doorway to give them time to look at him.

His burgundy-and-black tailcoat hung loosely. Beside his dark gloves, the white shirt seemed especially bright. His bow tie was straight; his pince-nez, slightly crooked. Long hair escaped beneath his bowler hat. His thin, pale face, beard, and mustache might have belonged to a wandering knight, if the knight had looked at people rather than through them.

The six rose.

Brown did not immediately invite them to sit. First he surveyed the

room: the candlesticks, the place settings, his chair, the little stage prepared against the far wall.

Antonio came up behind him and took his hat.

Brown passed a hand over his hair. He did not arrange it. He merely made sure everyone saw the gesture.

“There,” he said. “Much better.”

The king with the ring glanced at his neighbors.

Nobody asked what was better.

Brown sat. The others followed.

The young servant brought water. He approached from the correct side and did not touch the

candlestick. Brown did not even look at him. This was a relief.

“I hope our arrival hasn’t disrupted your plans,” said the eastern king.

“No.”

“We’re glad you were able to find the time.”

“You were very insistent.”

The king nodded.

They sat in silence for a while. Everyone could hear the words excluded from their courteous conversation. The servants moved between the chairs as carefully as if there were things on the floor that must not be touched either.

The first dish arrived under a cover.

The cover was lifted before Brown.

He looked at the dish, then at the guests.

Nobody asked what had been served. The cook had carried out his instructions. The sauce smelled of herbs, the hot dishes of an ordinary dinner. Candles shone in the silver.

The king in the dark coat picked up his fork.

He held it still for a while. Then he cut a small piece, noticed that everyone was watching, and stopped looking around.

Brown waited.

When the fork was laid beside the plate again, the others began to eat.

The gray-haired king drank some water. It seemed too warm. He meant to complain to the servant, but instead raised his glass again.

“Superbly prepared,” said the king with the ring.

Too loudly.

The eastern king inclined his head.

“Tell the cook.”

The young servant bowed. He had to carry the words to the kitchen. He repeated them to

himself on the way so that he would not bring any others.

The cook listened without raising his head.

“The next course is ready,” he said.

Antonio brought the special cup. He approached from the side the senior servant had shown him and set it before the king by the window.

The young servant stood by the candles. Antonio did not look at him as he returned to the wall. He held the tray with both hands, though it was empty now.

The king by the window did not reach for it at once. First he

checked the rim for fingerprints. It would have been easy to complain about the cleanliness of the cup, had the cup allowed him to think only about cleanliness.

It was made from the skull of a man he had spoken to that morning.

The king took a sip and passed it on.

Each tried not to meet the eyes of the man receiving it next. They held the cup carefully. They made sure not to spill the wine. They observed every rule they could still remember.

When it reached the gray-haired king, he hesitated.

Brown looked at him over his pince-nez.

“Is something wrong?”

The king lifted the cup.

“No.”

After that, the conversation gradually improved.

At first they spoke of things requiring no answer: the weather, how early it grew dark now. The king with the ring recalled an earlier performance and cautiously began retelling a funny incident. Halfway through, it emerged that the others had seen it too.

He stopped.

Brown smiled.

“Go on.”

“It’s hard to do it justice without you.”

“Of course.”

The king hastily agreed. The others liked this answer too. They would not have to establish exactly whom they had been laughing at.

The servants changed the plates.

After the second course, the man who had previously said very little remarked that the worst was over.

The king by the window put down his fork.

“Don’t spoil the evening.”

The other shrugged as though he had brought up an unfortunate incident from a journey.

Brown let them sit in silence.

The price had been stated in advance.

In return, they had asked for a performance.

Now the six sat before him, well dressed, surrounded by fire and silver, trying to look like men who had received exactly what they had come for.

Brown leaned back in his chair.

This had worked better than any of his previous acts.

Ice cream was served for dessert.

The guests knew about the addition to it. One had suggested preparing it this way himself, to show that the last part of the condition did not frighten him. Now he ate more slowly than the others and did not remind them whose idea it had been.

The young servant paused beside his chair.

“More?”

The king shook his head sharply.

“Don’t ask every time.”

The servant withdrew.

Brown raised a hand.

“I would ask. What else would you like?”

The king with the ring asked for tobacco.

Not the kind served in the palace. The rarest in the world, the sort of which one small pinch could supply an evening’s conversation.

A box was brought to him.

He read the label, sniffed it, tried to hide his surprise, and failed.

“Where did you—”

Brown did not let him finish.

“You asked for it.”

Another wanted a cognac no longer to be found even in the cellars of the man who had once

owned the last bottle. The bottle appeared on the table. Old dust coated the glass. A servant wiped it away to pour, and the king hurriedly stopped him: the dust had value too.

Special additions accompanied the tobacco and drinks. The ashes of the murdered man's bones were now called seasoning. It was a convenient word. One could ask whether enough had been added without saying enough of what.

Brown granted their wishes.

One guest asked for ever rarer things. Another increased the price, as though expense could trouble someone who did not intend to buy anything. A third

announced that he was difficult to surprise and smiled in advance, so no one would notice if he was surprised after all.

“What if I want something that doesn’t exist?” asked the king by the window.

“What, exactly?”

“Something that doesn’t exist anywhere.”

“Name it.”

The king looked at the eastern king, who lowered his glass from his lips.

In the room the king had left behind, they opened the window briefly each morning. The girl begged them not to close it, even

when she began to shiver. She liked hearing the gardener. In the last few days she had stopped asking.

“I would like—”

Brown waited. The other kings waited too. The men at the table already knew about the doctors. But to name her here, before Brown and the servants, would mean giving up the pretense that he had come only for a performance. His plea would be remembered word for word, repeated in other councils. The heir was ill. How ill? Who would follow her?

The king remembered the words he had already written for the

doctors. I give permission. He had not even managed to finish that letter.

“It isn’t a thing,” he said.

“Then why are you asking about a thing?”

The eastern king put down his glass.

“You can speak plainly here.”

The king by the window shot him a look. For a moment he thought the girl’s grandfather would say her name himself. But the older man fell silent.

“After the performance,” the king said to Brown. “If you could spare a few minutes.”

Brown shrugged.

“First let’s see whether you like the performance.”

“Of course.”

The words came easily. The king was almost glad to have put off, once again, the request he had come to make.

The king with the ring praised the tobacco again. Someone agreed too readily, and the conversation returned to rare things. Only the eastern king left his glass untouched.

Antonio stood near the wall.

He watched the servants, the bottles, made sure nobody waited too long. He did not eat. When the

young servant brought him water, he thanked him, took the glass, and put it on the nearest small table. Some time later, the water was still untouched.

Behind the fabric lay the puppets.

The awakened one could see the hall through a narrow gap. Once, such a gap had helped her judge when to raise a hand, turn her head, make someone else's joke funny. Now she watched the hands around the table.

All six men had clean hands.

One steadied a cup. Another adjusted a cuff. A third pointed out a spilled drop to a servant.

The puppet moved away from the gap.

Her wooden neighbor lay beside her. A string had caught at his elbow. She carefully freed it so that it would not pull on the joint, then laid it along his body.

She drew the next puppet closer.

Laughter came from the hall again.

She no longer wanted to know what it was about.

She knew what would happen next. Not the whole evening—only the part she knew how to do herself.

Brown would take the control bar. His first movement would be

too broad. She would soften it, pause at the edge of the light, turn her head, and the people beyond the sheet would laugh. The awkwardness would disappear. They could remember what they had come for and ask him to do it again.

She rested a hand on the rim of the box.

Before, she had worked for what came after the laughter. Brown would be pleased. The box would not be thrown into a corner; the strings would be untangled less hastily. Sometimes, in a good mood, he forgot the puppets altogether until morning. Then she could move without listening

for every footstep outside the door.

Tonight the box stood level. The lining was soft. Nobody had pulled her arm yet.

She still did not want to help.

Through the gap she could see Brown listening to a king, his head tilted slightly back. The man explained something, corrected himself, tried again. Brown could have answered, but let him struggle a little longer.

She wanted someone to look at Brown that way.

For him to make his familiar movement and get nothing but that movement. For them to wait

while he had nothing to fill the waiting with. Not alone behind a closed door. Here, before the men he had made beg.

She kept watching through the gap.

Once, the thought of his displeased face had been enough to make her invent another funny gesture. Now she pictured it clearly. How he would lean toward her. How he would look for a tangled string. How he would pull harder.

Her hand tightened a little on the rim.

She could make the act succeed. It would not change what had been served at this table tonight. Only

the faces around it would change. They would look relieved. That had happened after her performances before, though she had never watched them long enough.

She took her hand off the rim.

The strings were still attached. Brown could lift her, set her before the light, make her bow. She did not mean to hold her arms down, fight every pull. But where his movement ended and her own began, she would no longer carry on for him.

Through the gap she saw him hold out his empty glass without looking at the servant.

She moved back until his hand was out of sight.

Brown took off his gloves. The room was growing warm. He decided it was the candles and did not ask for any to be removed.

The king with the ring loosened a fastening. The gray-haired king looked toward the window.

The eastern king waited for the servants to finish changing the dishes.

11. The Feather

The eastern king put down his spoon.

The sound was slight, but the others heard it at once. Until then, each had been waiting for someone else to mention the performance. They could ask for more wine, complain of the stuffiness, praise the cook's skill. They had done all of that already. Brown granted their requests so readily that the most important request became harder and harder to make.

The king pushed his saucer away. A servant caught it before it stopped moving.

“An eagle once lived high in the mountains,” said the king.

Brown looked up.

“An excellent place for an eagle.”

“Certainly. He knew that better than we do. From his peak he could see every road into the valley, and not one led to his nest. The sun reached him earlier than anyone else. He could warm his wings while the people below were still asleep.”

The king spoke gently, almost confidentially, as if sharing a memory that had suddenly proved useful. His neighbor stopped turning an empty glass.

“One day, flying over a meadow, the eagle saw a beautiful young woman. She was gathering daisies. Not by the armful: she chose each flower, considered it, sometimes passed it by and came back. The eagle circled above her, his shadow sliding over the grass. She thought it was a cloud and was rather pleased. It was a hot day.”

Brown smiled. The eastern king answered with a slight inclination of his head.

“The eagle fell in love at first sight. He wanted to give her something beautiful. There was nothing suitable in the nest. He could bring a branch, but branches lay all around her; a

stone, but the mountain had stones enough for everyone. So he chose one of his most beautiful feathers."

"Plucked it out?" asked the neighbor with the glass.

"Gave it," said the eastern king.

His neighbor set the glass down.

"The feather began drifting toward the meadow. At first, she saw only a moving shadow. Then she looked up. Something long, golden in the sunlight, was turning slowly above her. She stepped back, and the gift settled at her feet, scarcely bending the daisies."

The king spread his hands to show its length.

“A meter and a half.”

Brown looked at the space between his hands with the approval of a man who would never have given a small feather.

“She put her flowers on the grass and lifted it. It was lighter than she had expected. She held it with both hands, and the wind tried to turn her along with the gift. She laughed and let go of one end. The feather rose above her head, shading her from the sun.”

The eastern king moved his glass but did not drink.

“All afternoon she walked through the meadow beneath it. It was cool in its shade. She could look at the flowers without squinting. When it was time to go home, she took both the daisies and the gift. It would never have occurred to her to leave such a thing beside the road.”

One of the listeners glanced at Brown. He was watching the storyteller. It was safe to go on listening.

“Toward evening, cold air came down from the mountains. She stopped beside a rock, shifted her flowers, and wrapped the feather around her shoulders. It bent without breaking. Its fine barbs lay close together, keeping the

cold from finding its way beneath her clothes. That was how she reached home."

"And the eagle?" Brown asked.

The eastern king paused for a moment.

"He saw that his gift had been useful."

Brown nodded, allowing him to continue.

"She took the feather with her many times afterward. On one of those days it rained. She sheltered the flowers beneath it, then sheltered herself. Drops gathered on its smooth surface and rolled off the edge. She stood on the road, listening to the rain

drum on her gift, and waited. Neither her clothes nor the daisies got wet."

A servant by the wall turned his head almost imperceptibly. He was listening, though his eyes were on the candles.

"Another day, a river blocked her way. Water flowed over the stones where people used to cross. She looked at the opposite bank for a long time. She could turn back, or search for a crossing until dark. But she had the feather."

The king picked up a folded napkin and set it before him, still folded, like a small raft.

“She lowered it onto the water and held it with one hand. It rocked beside the bank without sinking. Then she lay flat upon it, placed the flowers in front of her, and pushed off. The current carried her. She paddled with her hand until she reached a place where branches hung over the water. Catching one, she drew her raft to the bank and climbed onto the grass.”

The storyteller took his hand off the napkin.

“She pulled the feather out too. She shook it, the water ran off, and she could go on.”

For a few moments, the only sound in the hall was the faint crackle of a wick.

“That was the value of the eagle’s gift.”

Brown was the first to break the silence.

“A good eagle.”

“A generous one,” the eastern king agreed. “A gift useful in sunshine and bad weather alike is difficult to thank someone for in a single word.”

The others nodded. Now they understood why the mountain, the daisies, and the river crossing had been needed. They could join

the story without saying anything dangerous.

“We would not wish to seem ungrateful either,” the king continued. “You have given us an extraordinary evening.”

Brown leaned back.

“Not an evening yet. The beginning of one.”

“All the more reason. Even its beginning has been unlike anything we have known. We thank you for the meal and for this marvelous adventure into the world of magic.”

He spoke the last words with particular care. His neighbor reached for the wine, stopped,

and laid his hand on the table again.

“But a beautiful young woman does grow old,” the storyteller added gently.

Brown stopped smiling.

“What has that got to do with it?”

“Only that time passes even during happy anticipation. She might have grown old in the meadow if the eagle had taken too long to choose his feather. Fortunately, we have at last been able to meet you. Everything you asked has been done. Please allow us to see the performance for which we gathered.”

“Exactly,” one of the kings said quietly.

It sounded too much like a demand to him, so he added, “If you would be so kind.”

The eastern king corrected neither himself nor his neighbor. At last the request had been made. Any of the six could now look openly at the little stage instead of pretending to have happened to notice a sheet against the wall.

Brown took his time.

He had liked the story of the feather. But he liked its conclusion even more: everything had been done.

He looked around the table. Six men waited. Men who could not be approached without permission were asking him to come before them. Behind each stood gates, guards, staircases at whose foot petitioners had to stop. Tonight they were the ones sitting outside a closed door, choosing their words.

The eastern king still rested his palms on the table. Between them, the napkin remained folded into its little raft.

Brown thought he could make them wait longer.

It was a pleasant thought.

Against the far wall, a candle flame bent sideways.

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12. Not a Single Shadow

The young servant was the first to notice something wrong with the candles.

A flame bent almost to the wax, straightened, and bent again. Usually this meant someone had opened a door in the corridor. He looked. The door was shut.

Cold air passed along the floor. He felt it through his thin stockings. The edge of the tablecloth rose, fell, then crept upward again, as though someone beneath the table were cautiously straightening his back.

A candle went out.

The senior servant was already bringing a light. The young man cupped his hand against the draft, and for a few moments the flame steadied. The dry wick did not catch at once. Both stood motionless, waiting for it to burn properly.

Behind them, a second candle went out.

“The doors,” the older man said quietly.

The young servant went to check. He opened one a little and peered into the corridor. It was cool there, but he felt no draft. He shut the door firmly, held it with both hands, and turned.

The flames in the hall were still bending.

Above the table, the air grew hot. The king nearest Brown ran a finger inside his collar. Another dabbed his forehead with a napkin. Cool air moved low along the walls, while the air around Brown's chair felt heated, as though a stove stood beside it.

Brown saw no stove. He saw six kings waiting for his decision, and he was happy.

His own importance was expanding around him. It no longer fit beneath his burgundy-and-black coat. His hot ego pushed against the cool night air. Warm air rose; cold air

rushed to take its place, tugging at the tablecloth and the flames. Brown had long known how to turn a small desire into a change in the world outside him. Now he did not even notice he was doing it.

The young servant returned to the candlestick. His hand was not enough. He turned sideways, shielded the candle with his shoulder, and saw his shadow slide across the cloth toward a royal sleeve.

He stepped back at once.

The flame fluttered again.

“Lower,” whispered the older man.

The servant crouched. His shadow shortened, but his shoulder no longer protected the candle. He raised his hand; a black strip fell across the table. He lowered it and turned. Now he could shield the flame, but only until the next gust.

In these palaces, a servant’s shadow falling on his master was considered a curse. The young man knew the rule. He knew how to walk among steady candles, how to bend with a tray, which side to approach with water. Nobody had taught him how to cast no shadow when the light itself was running from side to side.

“What are you doing?” a king asked.

The servant froze in his awkward half-crouch.

“The candle, Your Majesty.”

“I can see the candle.”

The senior servant moved the candlestick a hand’s breadth to the side. The shadow slipped off the edge of the sleeve. The young man straightened just enough not to block the new light.

The king turned away.

At the other end of the table, the same thing was happening. People turned sideways, stretched out their arms, searched for a position in which

they could shield a flame without shielding anyone from it. From a distance, it resembled the start of a performance the audience was not yet prepared to judge.

Brown slowly rose.

His black gloves lay beside his place setting. He picked one up and pulled it on, straightening each finger, then put on the other. A white cuff emerged from his sleeve and disappeared again. Long hair clung to his thin cheek. He brushed it aside and adjusted his pince-nez. In the heat, his face remained pale.

Antonio approached with the bowler hat. Brown accepted it as though the hat had been the one

thing needed all along to put the room in order.

“My dear Antonio,” he said. “What is all this disorder?”

Antonio looked at the candles.

“They’re seeing to it.”

“You’ll frighten the guests. Look at their faces.”

The servants became even stiller. Antonio signaled to the senior man, who was already beside an extinguished wick.

Brown turned to the table.

“My dear guests, you have just been through a less than pleasant adventure. I must ask you to forgive me.”

The king who had just scolded the servant took his hand off the armrest. The eastern king listened without changing his position.

“However, it was all necessary.”

Brown paused. He liked the attention they were paying him and allowed it to continue.

“Your seventh companion was a spy.”

One of the six raised his head. Another glanced quickly at his neighbor, but the neighbor was looking at Brown.

“He intended to turn you against one another. Each of you would have heard exactly what he

needed to hear to start a war. You would have fought. He would have waited."

"Where?" someone asked.

"On his island. In Guatemala. You heard he was building a prison there?"

Someone nodded. Brown caught the movement and continued at once.

"Well, it wasn't a prison. A fortified refuge. Storehouses, walls, supplies—everything needed to sit out any war. Even if you had managed to invent the atomic bomb, he hoped to hide there until it was over. Let the others settle who was right. Then

come out and see what was left of them.”

The word “spy” hung in the room with the smoke from an extinguished wick.

The gray-haired king watched the speaker. He could have asked whom his brother had served, where the letter was, who had delivered the report. He could still have called him by his name instead of “the seventh companion.” It was a short name; he did not need to search his memory for it.

Brown looked toward the other end of the table, and the gray-haired king became afraid the explanation was about to

stop. Then there would be only what had been there before it: his brother's hand, waiting for an answer.

He did not say the name.

"He told me about the prison," said one king.

"Of course," Brown replied. "What else was he supposed to tell you?"

The king lowered his eyes. He remembered the mention of a prison very well. Nobody had told him about a refuge.

"So it was planned beforehand?" another asked.

"You're only realizing that now?"

Brown spread his hands. His black gloves were level with the seated men's faces.

"I have saved you a great deal of trouble."

The eastern king touched the edge of his napkin. It had been a neat rectangle; now one corner was turned up. He flattened it with his fingernail.

"Did you know this when you set the condition?" he asked.

Brown turned toward him.

"My dear fellow. If I knew no more than anyone else, why would you want my performance?"

He smiled as one smiles at a child who need not be told how a trick works.

The king looked at him a little longer, then took his hands off the table.

Brown produced no letter, no witness, no map of the island. He was speaking of rescue now, and it had become easier to listen. The kings could exchange glances for a different reason. One remembered a strange promise, another a postponed meeting. Before they could share these details, Brown raised his palm.

“But no more of that. You have gathered here for a miracle.”

The young servant held a candle at its base. Hot wax reached his finger. He shifted his grip slightly without taking his hand away. The relit flame was finally steady, and he did not want to risk it again.

Antonio went to the little stage and checked that the way was clear. The fabric stirred, its lower edge lifting and falling, but the fastenings held.

Brown noticed the movement.

“Antonio. The sheet.”

His assistant adjusted the bottom corner without pulling it too tight. Once, several other instructions would have followed: clear things

away, set the light, check the box. All of that had already been done.

Glasses remained on the table. The kings turned toward the stage.

Brown moved between the chairs. Heat came from his coat. The young servant waited for him to pass, then carried a candlestick to a place where its flame bent less. The senior man surveyed the table. The faces were lit.

For a moment, they could lower their hands.

Brown stopped beside the fabric. The puppet box stood within reach. At last every eye was where he wanted it.

“Well, then,” he said. “Let’s begin.”

13. The Performance

The control bar settled into his palm as it always had.

Brown did not even check that the strings were free. He raised his hand, waited for the wooden body to lift from its lining, and turned it toward the light.

The crack was still in her cheek.

He frowned. With money like his, every puppet could have had a new face. He could have commissioned an entire theater carved from wood found in only one place on earth. Why had nobody thought of it before?

The crack was old. Someone had once tried to cover it with red brick dust. Later, in good light, it had shown again.

Brown turned the puppet's unbroken cheek toward him.

He had done this many times.

Beyond the sheet, the audience settled more comfortably. The kings moved their glasses out of the way. One quietly told his neighbor that the real thing was beginning now.

Antonio adjusted the light.

The puppet's shadow grew across the sheet. Brown knew how it looked from the other side: a little wooden figure became a creature

that could fill the viewer's whole world. Every movement mattered. Any pause might make someone hold his breath.

He made the first movement.

The puppet raised her arm.

He made the second.

She took a step.

Now she should hesitate just a little. Stop, as though something unexpected had gotten in her way. Turn her head before the string told her to, then return it so quickly that the audience would never quite know why they had laughed.

Brown had never explained it to himself in those terms. He simply

knew: something funny happened next.

Nothing happened.

The puppet stood still.

He tilted the control bar.

The wooden head bobbed. An arm rose too high; a foot struck the edge of the table. It was a crude movement, without surprise or character. Only strings being pulled.

Someone in the hall coughed.

Brown waited.

The kings waited too. An initial failure could be part of the preparation. Sometimes an entertainer deliberately showed

how not to do something, then turned it into the best act of the evening with a single unexpected twist.

He jerked a string again.

The puppet bowed.

An ordinary bow.

Brown glanced quickly toward the table where he had left his glass. He had drunk enough tonight. More than before the London performance when he first heard a great hall stop breathing all at once. More than on many evenings after which they had begged him to stay another minute, give another act, take another bow.

The rule had been tested for years.

It could not stop working now.

Brown lowered his hand.

Usually the puppet continued. A slight delay, a gesture of her own, a turn toward an invisible neighbor—the things people later called the puppeteer's astonishing skill.

She hung limp.

On the other side of the sheet, someone shifted a chair. Its leg scraped the floor. The sound was clearer than any remark.

Brown lifted her again.

"Come on," he whispered.

The wooden hands stayed on their strings.

He brought his face close to hers. She smelled of old wood and warm paint. Through all the new theaters, palaces, and journeys, this puppet had never stopped smelling of the box.

“What’s wrong with you?”

The words escaped him.

He did not yet think he was asking someone.

The puppet’s feet rested on the edge of the table. The control bar was low; the strings hung slack. Not one could have pulled her head sideways.

She turned her head.

Only a little.

And looked straight at Brown.

He stopped breathing.

The painted smile had not suddenly widened. There was no new face. The old eyes were still the eyes someone had carved long ago. But the head had turned by itself, and Brown had seen it from too close to invent a trick of the light.

He remembered the imaginary chair occupied by an invisible guest. An empty hand raised at the right instant. A bow continuing after he had thought the performance over.

His own hands hanging helplessly behind the screen.

Other people's laughter in front of it.

He could have stopped. Lowered the bar carefully instead of dropping it. Given the small wooden body something to stand on and looked again, asking nothing in return.

The silence in the hall lengthened.

Brown heard it and chose something else.

"I don't need you," he said.

The puppet did not move.

“Need whom?” a king asked beyond the sheet.

Brown straightened abruptly.

The puppet was flung onto the lining. The control bar struck the edge of the box, overturned, and fell beside her. Its strings tangled with those already inside.

Brown came out from behind the sheet.

The six turned toward him.

He was smiling. Antonio had seen that smile before difficult conversations, when his employer had not yet decided whom to blame but already knew the fault belonged to someone else.

“You want a real miracle?” Brown asked.

The king with the ring nodded hastily.

“That’s why we—”

“I know why you’re here.”

He raised his hand.

A small flame rested on his palm. Not a candle, not a reflection. It held itself there, and Brown looked at it with relief. At least this belonged to him.

He closed his fingers, and the little flame went out.

But the heat around him kept growing.

The kings drew back from the table.

Brown's smile widened.

He could do things that needed no strings. Raise water, change the air, bring out of nothing what others thought impossible. He had helped where whole countries had failed. If he wished, he could bring rain here, night, a sunny day, set them all before these men and let them choose.

Nobody was allowed to doubt him over a wooden puppet.

"There," he said.

But the word was too small.

Heat swept through the hall. One side of the tablecloth lifted. A

glass overturned. A servant reached to steady a candlestick and snatched his hand away from the scorching metal.

Brown wanted everyone to look only at him.

Everyone was looking.

Now he needed more.

Behind the sheet, the puppet freed her hand from the tangled strings. Beside her lay the wooden neighbor whose elbow she had once freed from a loop. Another gust shifted him toward the edge of the box.

She caught him.

The lining rose. Another puppet rolled onto her side. The

awakened one pulled her closer, looped a long string around them together, and passed it under another wooden arm. They could not leave this place one at a time. The little bodies would scatter in different directions, and she would not be able to reach them.

She did not know what would happen next.

All she wanted was not to lose the others.

From the hall came an order to open the window.

Then not to open it.

“Antonio, the sheet!”

Brown’s voice was still recognizable.

His assistant turned toward the stage. The fabric had lifted at the bottom, exposing the table legs. He needed to go around to the left, take hold where the fastening was stronger, and pull it down. He had already reached out.

At the table, the young servant had picked up the candlestick again, using a napkin folded several times. Wax ran onto the cloth. The candles leaned in different directions; he could not hold the heavy base and straighten them at the same time.

“Higher,” said the senior servant.

The young man raised the candlestick.

His shadow crossed a king's face.

He saw it. Before, he would have stepped back first and only then thought about where to put his foot. Now he looked down.

There was an empty space beside the wall.

He crouched and set the candlestick on the floor. The base rocked. Holding it through the napkin, he waited until it stood firmly, then took his hands away.

"What are you doing?"

He straightened.

The shadow grew larger still. The young servant did not crouch again or look for another place for the light. He stepped away

from the candles, holding his burned hand against his chest.

Antonio left the sheet.

A chair stood between them. He pushed it, but a leg caught in a fold of the carpet. He had to take hold with both hands and lift. The chair struck the table. A glass fell, and for the first time Antonio did not look to see who had noticed.

“Antonio!”

He heard.

The young servant looked at the outstretched hand and moved his burned palm away from his chest.

“Not that one,” Antonio said.

The servant opened his other hand. He took hold himself, firmly, with his whole hand. Antonio drew him into the passage between the wall and the table, where there were no candles.

A fastening cracked near the stage.

Brown called him again, clearly, by his full name, as though order could still be restored by leaving no doubt about whom he was addressing.

Antonio did not answer. He offered his shoulder for the young man to lean on and took another step. Under his arm, the

mended seam of his vest began to tear.

Behind him, one corner of the sheet fell to the floor.

Brown stood in the middle of a light he had not meant to kindle. The little flame had long since gone out. His palm was empty. He lowered his hands, but the radiance remained around him, at his chest, his face, above his head.

The heat grew with his importance.

His power had stopped obeying him as suddenly as the puppet had a minute earlier. But he could not throw this power into a box and turn away.

The king by the window stood. His chair fell.

Brown saw the movement and was angry. Were they going to leave again before he had finished?

The thought made it hotter still.

He wanted to tell them to stay where they were.

Light came from his mouth instead of words.

For an instant, Brown saw the whole room. Six crowns. An overturned chair. White fabric concealing nothing now. Beside the little stage, a bundle of wooden figures pressed together.

They had not done this to him.

He did not have time to finish the thought.

The air burst into flame.

Sound followed light, but none of the seven men for whom the evening had been arranged remained to hear it. Tom Brown and the six kings died together. Their argument over who would get more ended before they finished dividing the valley.

Where his ego had swollen, a star was born.

From far away, it looked like a little dot.

In the margins: 25 · 26 · 27

14. A Star Named Ego

A new star appeared in the sky.

Its light was beautiful.

From a distance, nothing else could be said of it. The light shone steadily, forming neither words nor warnings. Watch it long enough, and you wanted to come closer.

The star was not on the old charts.

The first captains were delighted by this. Where a chart shows nothing, a person can sometimes put his own name. It is not every day that one gets to sign a piece of sky.

Spacecraft changed course.

At first, all went well. Instruments worked. People recorded readings, argued about distances, passed cups to one another. Someone said the light was extraordinary. Someone else said there was nothing extraordinary about it; people simply ought to look out the window more often.

Such a conversation could happen near any star.

Then the man who looked out the window more often noticed that, really, the others saw nothing at all.

They disagreed.

He was surprised. People had not always listened to him before, but before, that had seemed acceptable. Now it did not. Surely it was obvious who understood more than anyone else here. He could give examples. He gave them, calmly at first, then more loudly, because he was being interrupted by people who ought to have learned to keep quiet.

On one of the first ships, the quarrel began with a chair.

The copilot adjusted the back before his watch. The captain said that made it uncomfortable.

“It’s comfortable for me,” said the copilot.

“I spend longer in it than you do.”

“That’s why I have to keep adjusting it.”

The engineer, who had been silently checking the instruments, turned toward them.

“If I didn’t keep fixing things after you two, you’d never get anywhere.”

A cup grew cold beside the controls. Nobody noticed. All three noticed the others’ tone perfectly well.

The captain demanded silence.

It was the last thing to demand of men each already preparing to explain to the other two exactly what sort of people they were.

The ship kept going.

They were lucky. Their course did not lead straight toward the star. It passed it, and after a while the distance began to increase.

The engineer was the first to stop in mid-sentence.

He had been about to say something precise and final. While searching for the words, he found it was not so precise after all. At any rate, it should not be said. He turned back to his instruments.

The copilot let go of the chair back.

The captain looked at the clock.

“How long have we—” he began, and stopped.

Nobody answered.

He picked up the cup, drank, and grimaced. Cold.

That evening they put it down to fatigue. None of them had rested properly in a long time. Anything could happen in a cramped cockpit. The chair really had needed adjusting too.

But the records remained.

The time, the distance from the star, and three voices difficult to listen to even one at a time.

Later, other records emerged. Other ships, other chairs, cups, excuses. Someone took offense at a chart handed to him the wrong way. Someone decided that being

asked to repeat a reading insulted his intelligence. On one ship, two people nearly quarreled over whose idea something had been, although both had already forgotten the idea.

Too many things matched.

Especially the distance.

A line was drawn around the new star on the charts.

Not the border of anyone's property. Not an invitation to people who enjoyed crossing borders. Just a line beyond which people grew less able to understand what lines were for.

The star was named Ego.

It was a short name. It fit neatly on a chart.

The warning beside it took up more room.

Not everyone read it.

There were captains who believed caution had been invented for less capable captains. They pointed to the line, smiled, and said they knew their own ship perfectly well.

The closer they came, the more convincing their own words sounded.

The danger did not always begin in anger. Sometimes a person felt extraordinarily lighthearted. Everything became clear. Earlier

doubts seemed an irritating illness from which he had finally recovered.

He was great.

Not someday, after years of work. Now.

Therefore he could do what others dared not. Therefore he had no need to check a calculation twice, heed a warning, or wait for ordinary preparations to be completed. Those things were for ordinary people. The stupidest thing he could do was continue to think himself one of them.

Then he did something else stupid.

Sometimes the last thing he ever did.

Ego did not wreck the ship for him. His hands found things they would not have touched before. His voice gave an order that would have sounded insane yesterday. If anyone nearby was still capable of objecting, he took the objection for envy.

On larger ships, it was worse.

Suddenly there were many captains.

Not assistant captains. Not people willing to take a watch while someone else rested. Each was the only person who ought to be trusted with everything, and each

found himself surrounded by strangers obstructing justice.

Words became threats.

Threats became weapons.

Afterward, the ship might still be in working order. Lights burned. Instruments functioned. An open chart lay on the table, its warning plainly visible.

There was simply no one left to steer away.

So watches were not missed near Ego. People did not trust themselves to notice their own foolishness in time. A sleeping man might wake with the splendid certainty that he was the greatest being in the universe

and had, for some reason, been entrusted with such a small ship.

Those who managed to leave regained their old sense of proportion: the distance between themselves and the rest of the world.

Once again, it was possible not to know an answer.

They could ask someone to explain.

They could say, “You were right,” without disappearing, shrinking, or losing their names.

There was no ceremony to it. Nobody presented awards for recovered common sense. One person pushed a cup toward

another. Someone made room at the controls. A man began an apology and got stuck on the first word; the others nodded, remembering their own words as clearly as his.

Then they checked their course.

Black holes were feared too. But people could at least agree about a black hole: it threatened the body.

Ego took away the very thing that let a person recognize a threat.

On new charts, the safe perimeter was marked especially clearly. The route around it was longer than the straight one. Time had to be spent on a curve, although nothing in the beautiful light

ahead seemed to prevent a direct approach.

Ships took the curve.

Not all of them. But those that returned recommended it.

From a distance, the star was still beautiful.

In the margins: 28

15. Every String

One ship was leaving Ego under manual control.

Raccoon and Kwark were aboard. Raccoon stood by the viewing window; Kwark watched the distance on the chart. Here, both found it harder than usual not to interrupt each other. Raccoon had explained twice already that he could see the star without a chart, and twice Kwark had answered that this was precisely why he was watching the chart himself. The third time, they kept quiet.

“It’s smaller,” Raccoon said at last.

“Yes.”

“You can see that, at least.”

Kwark looked out of the window.

“You can.”

The distance was growing. The bright spot of the star moved slowly toward the edge of the viewing window. On the chart, the gap between the ship and the warning line was narrowing. They needed to keep moving away, and the ship did.

Nobody intended to search for wreckage there.

They noticed it by chance.

At first it was a small dark patch against the light. It turned and

changed shape, stretching out, then becoming almost round. Thin things stuck out of it in different directions.

“Wood,” said Raccoon.

Kwark came closer to the window.

Kwark was a lizard. When he examined something he did not understand, he tilted his head a little, as though looking at it sideways might make it clearer. Sometimes it helped.

Raccoon preferred to come closer and touch it.

This time there was too much empty space between him and

the discovery. He put a paw against the glass.

“How did wood get here?”

“I don’t know yet.”

“Then we should have a look.”

Before Kwark could point out that they were already looking, Raccoon indicated a small screen where they could see it enlarged.

It really was wood.

But not a branch.

Dark sticks crossed one another. Between them something round and flaking appeared, marked with an uneven red streak. The bundle slowly turned, and for an

instant a little foot came into view.

Kwark leaned forward.

“Wait.”

“I am waiting.”

“No, not you.”

The object did not wait. It continued its quiet turn, hiding the foot among the sticks again.

The ship did not turn back toward the star. When the bundle came within reach, a mechanical arm extended outside. Its metal fingers opened beside the wooden ones, which were absurdly small in comparison.

Raccoon watched the screen without looking away.

“Don’t squeeze.”

The fingers closed around the bundle.

They did not crush it.

“That’s it,” said Raccoon, although the arm had already done everything required of it.

The bundle disappeared from view.

The ship kept moving away and soon crossed the danger line. Ego lay behind them. On the chart, the distance to it increased; beyond the window, its light grew smaller. The star had not gone

out or become harmless. It was simply far enough away now.

Raccoon looked at the chart beside Kwark once more. Then they went to see what they had found.

Now they could look at it without glass between them.

Puppets lay on the floor.

Several wooden bodies pressed tightly together. Arms, legs, heads. Old paint worn smooth where they had been handled too often, uneven where someone had painted them in a hurry. Control bars protruded from the bundle. Strings passed around shoulders, beneath elbows, joined

legs together, and vanished inside again.

Raccoon crouched.

Kwark stayed beside him, tilted his head, and cautiously touched a control bar.

A wooden arm rose.

He lowered it immediately.

“Marionettes,” he said.

“What?”

“Puppets. You pull these strings and they move.”

Raccoon looked more closely at the strings.

“Nobody’s pulling now.”

“Not now.”

Raccoon slipped a paw beneath the bundle and lifted it a little. All the puppets rose together. One head swung, came to rest against a neighboring shoulder, and stayed there.

“They tied themselves together,” said Raccoon.

“I can see.”

“So they wouldn’t get lost.”

Kwark opened his mouth to explain how a puppet theater worked, then looked at the knots again.

The strings did not lead only to the control bars. They held the puppets beside one another. Here, one loop caught another;

there, several strings had been gathered into a tight cord. It was an awkward, lopsided bundle.

But nobody was separate.

That was the idea.

The puppet with the flaking cheek still held someone else's arm against her. She remembered the light after which there had been neither floor nor stage. She remembered how important it was not to let go of whatever she had managed to catch.

After that, there was no up or down.

There were the other puppets.

If their wooden elbows knocked against her, they were still close. If a string tugged at her shoulder, someone was still at the other end. Once, such a tug had meant raise your arm, bow, take a step. Now it meant only: not lost.

She did not know how long they had been like that.

She did not know whether anyone would notice them.

Now there was a floor beneath them again. A striped face bent over them, and large paws tried not to break anything.

“There,” said Raccoon. “Now we can.”

He put the bundle down and fetched scissors.

“What are you going to do?” asked Kwark.

“Untie them.”

“You brought scissors.”

Raccoon looked at the scissors, then at the knots.

“It’s quicker.”

The first string had to be pulled away a little. It ran tightly beside a wooden shoulder. Raccoon slipped the tip of the scissors beneath it, paused to make sure he had caught nothing else, then closed the blades.

A short end fell to the floor.

The puppet did not fall.

He cut the next string.

Kwark held a control bar so that it would not hit anyone on the head. Little by little, the puppets came apart. Small gaps opened between them. A knee appeared from beneath someone else's elbow, and a little palm that had been hidden before.

"Another one here," said Kwark.

Raccoon carefully turned the bundle.

One puppet remained in his paw. The others lay on the floor.

He set the freed one beside them and began on another loop.

“You can leave those,” Kwark observed when Raccoon reached the strings leading straight to a control bar. “They’re for the performance.”

Raccoon hesitated.

“Is there going to be a performance now?”

Kwark looked around the empty compartment.

“I don’t think so.”

“Then what for?”

The scissors clicked again.

Kwark was about to say something else, but Raccoon was already checking the other arm for a remaining string. There was

nothing ceremonial about it. He was freeing the things they had found, just as he would free anyone tangled in rope who could not get out.

At last the floor held separate control bars, cut ends, and one long, tangled heap of strings.

Every string had been cut.

Raccoon swept a paw across the floor beside the last puppet, moving the scraps away so she would not get caught in them again.

“That’s better.”

The puppet with the flaking cheek sat with her legs stretched

out. Nothing pulled at her neck anymore. She raised her arm.

The arm rose.

Not one control bar moved.

Kwark saw it.

Then the puppet turned to her neighbor and straightened her neighbor's awkwardly tucked leg.

Raccoon smiled.

"See? Just tangled up."

Kwark looked at him, at the scissors, at the free wooden hands.

"You've gone and done something good out of sheer foolishness again," he said softly.

Raccoon stopped smiling.

“Why foolishness?”

“You set them free.”

“I said I would right from the start.”

Kwark was quiet for a moment.

“Yes,” he agreed. “You did.”

Raccoon began gathering the scraps.

A little bundle slipped from the cuff of the neighbor in striped trousers. The puppet recognized the scrap of cloth and caught it before Raccoon’s paw could sweep it up with the strings. Inside was the hand she had once carried from the far end of a

bench. The string at its wrist had been cut too.

Raccoon drew back his paw.

The puppet put the bundle beside the empty sleeve. It stayed with them.

She tried to lean on her arm to move closer to the others. Her shoulder sank before her elbow did. Something crunched dryly inside, and a little wood dust fell to the floor.

She drew the arm against her.

Raccoon stopped gathering scraps.

“That isn’t holding very well.”

He reached out a paw, but the puppet turned away, covering her shoulder with her other hand.

The paw stopped.

For a while Raccoon sat with it in the air. Then he put it on his knee.

Kwark tilted his head. This time he did not need a different angle to understand what was in front of him. He watched the little hand she was shielding herself with.

“Let me fetch something soft,” he told Raccoon.

Raccoon nodded.

The puppet stayed where she was. Neither of them reached after her. While Kwark was gone,

Raccoon moved the scissors farther from her feet and took the last control bar out of the tangled strings. The wood had darkened at one end, but its middle was sound, worn smooth by years of handling.

He laid it across his knees.

Kwark returned with a piece of soft cloth. He folded it several times to make a low cushion. It was not as handsome as the lining of the old box: a crooked seam ran along its edge, and one corner had to be tucked under to keep it from curling up.

“Here?” he asked.

Raccoon looked at the puppet.

She was looking at her neighbors.

They put the cushion beside the others, leaving a little bare floor between its edge and her feet. This place had no walls and no lid.

For a long time the puppet did not move.

Meanwhile, Raccoon examined the control bar. He took out a small knife and held it against the middle, but did not start cutting yet. Now and then he looked at her shoulder. He did not reach for it again.

Someone had made a soft place for her once before. Afterward, they had still lifted her by the strings every evening, and her

shoulder had sunk farther beneath her costume. She remembered how carefully they had carried the new box. She remembered hitting its soft bottom too.

Now there were no strings. That did not yet make it obvious where to put her hand.

She leaned forward, supporting herself on her good arm, and touched the edge of the cloth. It crumpled beneath her palm. Then she moved one leg, then the other, and sat on the cushion herself.

Raccoon took the control bar off his knees and laid it on the floor.

“May I have a look?”

The puppet looked down at his paw. It lay open beside her, much bigger than her whole hand.

She touched it with the tips of her wooden fingers.

Raccoon did not close his paw around them.

Then she rested her whole hand on it. She leaned a little to one side so he could see her shoulder. To do that, she had to turn her damaged cheek toward the light. Nobody turned it away again.

Raccoon supported her arm from below. Kwark gently drew back the edge of her little sleeve; the puppet held the cloth with her free hand.

The joint in her shoulder had been loose for a long time. In places, the wood around the hole was dark and crumbling. Where a string had once held the arm, nothing now stopped it from slipping down.

Raccoon did not test how far it would slip.

“I can’t fix all of it,” he told Kwark.

“Could you keep it from coming out?”

Raccoon glanced at the control bar beside him.

“I’ll try.”

He tucked a rolled edge of cloth beneath her arm and slowly

withdrew his paw. Her arm's weight rested on the soft cloth. The puppet moved her elbow a little, making herself more comfortable.

Raccoon made a small wooden peg from the sound middle of the control bar. Kwark held the piece of wood while he worked. The shavings were pale and fresh, nothing like the dark dust from her shoulder. Now and then Raccoon held the little piece against his own claw, frowned, and shaved off a little more.

The puppet watched what remained of the control bar. One end was still smooth, familiar to someone else's hand. The holes the strings had passed through

were still there too. But this piece of wood could no longer hold her above the floor.

At last Raccoon laid the peg beside her hand.

She touched it, rolled it on the cloth, and looked at her shoulder.

Then she offered her arm again.

Raccoon bent over her. His paws were too big for work like this, and he kept changing position so as not to block his own light. Kwark moved to keep his shadow off her shoulder.

When the wood gave a faint creak, the puppet pulled her arm back.

Raccoon let go at once. Kwark held only the cushion, to keep it from slipping.

The peg was still only partway in.

The puppet sat with her arm pressed to her chest. Nothing happened. They did not put her back in position. Raccoon laid down his tool.

“I was holding it awkwardly,” he said.

Kwark straightened the rolled edge of cloth, but did not move it toward her.

Something hummed softly beyond the compartment wall. Sometimes the sound changed, deepening a little before

becoming steady again. In the past, a voice had always followed a pause: the next act, the next bow. Even now, she listened for that voice to begin.

Raccoon silently brushed the shavings from his knees. One thin curl caught in his fur; it took him a moment to remove it.

The puppet watched the curl, then looked at the tool he had put down.

This time she moved the soft roll beneath her elbow herself. She rested her arm on it and touched Raccoon's paw with her free hand.

He looked up.

She turned her shoulder a little toward him.

Now Raccoon settled lower, almost lying on the floor. Kwark stepped a little to one side so the light could reach her shoulder again. The work did not take long. They had spent much longer simply sitting beside her.

When the little piece was in place, Raccoon took both paws away.

The arm stayed at her shoulder.

The puppet did not dare raise it at once. First she moved only her hand. Then she bent her elbow, lifted it off the cloth, and lowered it. She could still feel the weakness in the old wood; she did not raise her arm very high.

“Shall we leave it like that?” asked Raccoon.

She touched the new peg. Then she rested her hand on the cushion and did not hold it out again.

Raccoon pushed the tool aside.

The wood around the hole was no sounder than before. The old crack still ran across her cheek, with dark red dust deep inside it. The arm held better, but for now it still needed a soft support. Raccoon left the roll of cloth where she had put it.

Kwark moved the spare cloth off her lap.

The puppet raised her good arm. She stopped halfway and turned her palm up. Then down. The movement led nowhere; nobody was meant to see a king, a petitioner, or an invisible guest in it.

She did it again, more slowly.

Raccoon was already gathering his tools. Kwark helped him look for the knife, which had disappeared beneath the edge of the cloth.

“By your paw,” he said.

“Where?”

“Your other one.”

Raccoon found the knife and put it away.

The puppet lowered her arm. She did not have to finish with a bow.

The others lay or sat nearby, just as they had been placed after the strings were cut. One head rested on another's shoulder. The puppet pulled the edge of her cushion toward them; Raccoon helped spread the cloth without moving anyone away from her.

He picked up the remains of the control bar last. It was not tied to any puppet again.

The ship traveled on.

Here nobody demanded that the puppets go onstage.

Nobody lifted them from the floor by a string.

The puppet with the flaking cheek turned toward the others. They were all close. Now she could move away from them, find a place of her own closer to the compartment wall. No string would stop her or drag the others after her.

She stayed.

She moved only a little, making room for the one at the edge.

Brown was gone. There was no one left to show who had really brought his performances to life. No one left to pay back for the pain he had caused without even noticing. The puppet had waited so long for his power to end that

she did not immediately know what to do after the ending.

Her neighbor's hand lay beside her, the one she had saved, still in its scrap of cloth.

She unfolded the cloth and took the hand in her own.

That could be done without a string.

The ship still had a journey ahead of it. The puppets would travel with Raccoon and Kwark—not toward another performance, not following a master.

Simply onward.

In the margins: 29 · 30 · 31 · 32

The Other Side of the Map

An independent story lives in the margins.

> *I finished the map to our tent. Can you see the tent?*

Back to the story

> *Yes. Not the entrance. It's behind a mountain on the map.*

Back to the story

> *The mountain's the chair. Go round its left side.*

Back to the story

> *There's a wall on the left. I'm here already.*

Back to the story

You're on the wrong side.

Back to the story

I'm at the door. That's where you start.

Back to the story

Turn the map round, then.

Back to the story

Now the door's on the window.

Back to the story

Let's try together. I'll start at the tent, you at the door.

Back to the story

I'll take water. A proper expedition.

Back to the story

The map's on the floor. Don't put your glass on it. Here's the turn.

Back to the story

I'll go over the cushion. It's shorter.

Back to the story

The cushion's slipping! Hold on to the chair.

Back to the story

The glass is all right. There's a river on the map now.

Back to the story

My lake's running. So's the mountain.

Back to the story

Sorry. I'll dry it. Next time I'll take an empty glass.

Back to the story

Wait. Let's dry the floor first. Then try with water again.

Back to the story

First show me where you were when you said "left."

Back to the story

Here. I see the seat. You see the back.

Back to the story

Exactly. We went round the same leg on different sides.

Back to the story

I'll tie a blue ribbon round this leg. And draw that.

Back to the story

Two turns, but no cushion. All right. I'll carry it around.

Back to the story

There's a dry edge on the back. I'll try to fit the path there.

Back to the story

With the pretty side underneath?

Back to the story

This bit is still dry. Here's the door. Start here.

Back to the story

Past the blue ribbon. Then the rug. I'm not running.

Back to the story

You made it. Is the glass full?

Back to the story

Not quite. I had a drink on the way.

Back to the story

You draw the way back. I'll draw it from here again.

Back to the story

Both arrows fit. Not much room left for the mountain.

Back to the story

Leave the mountain for now. We might go somewhere else tomorrow.

Back to the story

I'll leave this bit white. And put the glass on the floor.

Back to the story

Where will the next path lead?